Dragon Raja I

The Blazing Dawn

Jiang Nan

English Translation Working Draft

This draft contains the complete prologue and Act One. The remainder of Volume I and the other four books have not yet been translated.

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Prologue White Emperor City
Act One The Gate to Cassell

When you are at your loneliest and most hopeless, a door will open beside you.

Lu Mingfei waited eighteen years. At the lowest, most pathetic moment of his life, the door opened.

This book is dedicated to every hapless kid with a dream.

Jiang Nan

Prologue

White Emperor City

The fate of the forsaken is to cross the wilderness, raise their battle banners once more, and return to their homeland.

Death is nothing to fear. It is only a long sleep.

Until I can devour this world, I would rather sleep in peace than wander alone.

We will wake again.

"Brother…" Someone was calling softly in the dark.

How annoying. Whose kid had gotten lost?

"Brother," the child called again.

Annoying, annoying, annoying! Brother? No brothers here!

"Brother… I'm going now…" the child murmured, his voice fading into the distance.

Suddenly, he felt a little bad. There was a loneliness in that receding voice. He could almost see the child walking away, like an abandoned little hound.

"All right, all right, all right! What street do you live on? What number? Which door? What's your useless brother's name? I'll take you home!" He rolled over and sat up.

He was sitting on the floor in the sunlight, dressed in white as luminous as the moon. Before him, a white camellia bloomed in a coarse porcelain vase. On the other side of the flower, the child, also in white, bent over a desk with an ink brush in his hand, carefully writing one stroke at a time.

Hey, you haven't left? Were you messing with me? He wanted to say it, but didn't.

Instead, he did something that felt perfectly natural. There was a plate of glistening green grapes on the table. He picked off a small cluster and passed it across to the child.

The child looked up, alarm flickering in his eyes like a startled young animal's. "Brother, there are a lot of people outside."

Bullshit. It's so quiet, he thought.

But just as naturally, something else came out of his mouth. "We may die, I suppose. But don't be afraid, Constantine."

"I'm not afraid. As long as I'm with you, I'm not afraid… But why… won't you eat me? If you ate me, there's no prison you couldn't break out of." The child was completely serious.

Eat… you? Sure, you're all pale and tender-looking, but that doesn't mean you'd taste better than a hamburger. I had one for lunch. I'm not hungry at all, he thought.

"You would make fine food. But then I would be too lonely. For thousands of years, you've been the only one with me." Once again, his words were nothing like his thoughts.

"But dying really is so sad. It's like being sealed inside a black box, forever and ever, pitch-black… Like feeling your way through the night, but no matter how far you reach, your hands never touch a thing…"

"The fate of the forsaken is to cross the wilderness, raise their battle banners once more, and return to their homeland. Death is nothing to fear. It is only a long sleep. Until I can devour this world, I would rather sleep in peace than wander alone. We will wake again." He could hardly believe such outrageously cool lines were coming out of his mouth.

"Brother… when you raise the battle banners and devour the world, will you eat me?" The child looked at him, something flickering in those clear eyes… anticipation.

What the hell? Was this a scene from We're One Big Happy Cannibal Family? Your family values are seriously weird!

"Yes. And then you and I will reign over the world together!" Yet he nodded gently, his voice carrying a cold, unyielding authority.

The child poured a cup of water from a pitcher and handed it to him. He drank it in a daze.

"I'm leaving now, Brother. Goodbye." The child stood up.

He wanted to say, I'm not your brother. You've got the wrong person. Instead, he merely said, "Goodbye. Take care of yourself. Humans… cannot be trusted."

Another strange line, completely out of nowhere.

The child went outside and closed the door behind him. He listened as the footsteps grew fainter and fainter, until they disappeared altogether.

Suddenly, he was a little frightened. What had he been thinking, letting a child that small walk out into the streets alone? What if someone snatched him? Who knew how far he would have to go to find his brother? He grew restless. At last, unable to bear it any longer, he got up and ran for the door.

He pushed it open. Fierce light fell across his white clothes—not sunlight, but firelight. Beneath flames that scorched the sky, the city was screaming. Charred human figures ran through the fire. Thousands upon thousands of arrows rained down. A huge burning signboard tumbled from above, the words WHITE EMPEROR written across it. It was hell itself.

At the very center of the city stood a tall pole. The child hung at its top, his eyes closed, and all the flames in the city were burning him.

It was like some grand sacrifice.

His heart hurt so much, as though a knife were cutting into it. Someone precious had been lost, because he had made a mistake.

Then, suddenly, he remembered. Yes. He really was that child's brother.

"Constan… tine." He called the name.

He jerked upright, opening his eyes in the afternoon sunlight, gasping for breath and drenched in cold sweat. Outside came the rumble of a train passing on the elevated tracks.

All at once, that noise sounded wonderful. It reminded him that everything in the dream had been false. He was here, in the ordinary human world.

Act One

The Gate to Cassell

A few times in every life, you feel as though you have seen the gates of heaven swing open. Lu Mingfei had waited eighteen years. At the lowest, most pathetic moment of his life, the gates finally opened.

The angel who walked in swept her gaze around the room, her eyes sharp as knives.

Lu Mingfei typed "GG"—"Good Game," a compliment to your opponent in competitive gaming, and also an admission of defeat—and exited the game.

The last image on the screen was of twelve Terran battlecruisers concentrating their Yamato cannon fire on his Hatchery, turning it into a pool of blood.

He had lost his sixth match of the day. Zero wins, six losses. He had held out for twenty-two minutes and twenty-three seconds in the last one, but had gone down in the end. His opponent had excellent micro, and he played Terran. Marines were an absurdly overpowered unit in StarCraft: no delay before firing, just raise the gun and shoot, lower it and run. Lu Mingfei's Zerglings couldn't catch them, and got picked off one after another along the way.

His opponent was crowing in the chat. "You don't necessarily need tanks when you play Terran against Zerg. The Korean pros don't even build tanks. You just pump out units right from the start, send in a ton of Marines mixed with Medics, keep wearing them down while you push…"

Lu Mingfei could picture the guy's smug, animated face.

He said nothing and switched to QQ. The avatar of the girl in a baseball cap was still gray and motionless. She hadn't come online. Another pointless wait. He scratched his head, a little disappointed. A different avatar began bouncing instead: a panda with an eminently punchable face. The screen name was "Old Tang."

"You're pretty good with Zerg, bro. Let's go again sometime!" Old Tang was the guy who had beaten him. "It's just your micro that needs work. Your strategy's solid."

"Sure," Lu Mingfei said.

Old Tang logged off, full of himself. Lu Mingfei stuck his tongue out at the screen.

If Old Tang had seen how Lu Mingfei was actually playing, he probably wouldn't have felt so pleased. He would have called him a freak and never played him again. Lu Mingfei was using an old IBM laptop with no mouse attached, controlling everything with the little red pointing stick. Only a lunatic would play StarCraft on a pointing stick. It was like cleaning your ears with a rolling pin. If he plugged in a mouse, Old Tang probably wouldn't make it to the eight-minute mark. But then how would he kill the time?

Besides, Lu Mingfei couldn't be bothered to explain that he was only making things harder for himself out of boredom. He had a lot of time to kill. What if Old Tang refused to play next time?

But however much time he killed, she still didn't come online.

Why bother? Sometimes he asked himself that. Waiting and waiting like an idiot, four hours for two or three lines of conversation. It hardly seemed worth it.

But who could calculate what something like that was worth?

“A case of that milk in bags that’s on sale, half a jin of Cantonese sausage, and the new issue of Fiction Illustrated for Mingze. Come straight back when you’re done, and trim the celery on the table! And check the gatehouse for letters from America! Still playing games? You don’t care about your own future at all! If nobody admits you, do you think you can get into a first-tier university on your exam scores? All that money we’ve spent on you—what good has it done?” His aunt’s voice thundered from the next room.

His head buzzing, Lu Mingfei rattled off a string of yeses and scurried out. The hallway was quiet. Afternoon sunlight came through the window at the end of the stairwell, spilling warm across him. Pure white sheets hung along the corridor. Outside, the wind stirred glossy green leaves with a rustling sound. He leaned against the door, listening to his aunt’s endless complaints inside. With the door between them, it seemed to belong to another world.

Spring again. Lu Mingfei, senior in high school, nearly eighteen.

He lived with his uncle and aunt and had a younger cousin named Lu Mingze. He attended the most prestigious private high school in the city: steep tuition, stern teachers, luxury cars streaming past, beautiful girls drifting by like clouds. In three months and four days, he would have to sit the national college entrance exam. These days, everyone he met earnestly informed him that doomsday was approaching and he ought to get fired up.

But the more pressure there was, the lazier Lu Mingfei became. When he wasn’t playing StarCraft, he lay on his bed staring at the ceiling.

For someone whose presence barely registered, his laziness was easy enough to understand.

Lu Mingfei hadn’t seen his parents in more than six years. The good news was that they were supposedly still alive, and wrote him a letter every six months. The bad news was that every time they wrote, his mother regretfully explained that their plan to return to China to visit him had been postponed again, because “there have been new developments.”

His parents were both archaeologists, supposedly working on a major project whose results, once announced, would astonish the world as much as Sven Hedin’s discovery of ancient Loulan. In middle school, Lu Mingfei had been very proud of them. He read lots of books about archaeology and talked about it enthusiastically with his classmates on the way home. But he soon realized that the ones who should be proud were the guys whose parents came to pick them up. After school, a pack of boys would saunter down the street side by side, taking up nearly half the road. Then a car horn would sound behind them, and one of the guys would instantly stop swaggering, climb obediently into the family car, and disappear. One by one they peeled away, until usually only Lu Mingfei remained, still swaggering along by himself.

Looking out through their car windows, the others watched him kick a stone and wander freely into the distance, and envied him terribly. He could go anywhere he wanted. Browse a mall, buy a snack, even shoot some pool.

“Lu Mingfei’s family treats him the best. They never make him do anything.”

In fact, when Lu Mingfei was alone, he didn't browse malls or play pool. Once he had sat in the internet café long enough to feel sick of it, he went home. But after entering the building, he didn't go inside the apartment. He squeezed through the iron grating that led to the roof, sat beside a humming air-conditioning unit, and looked out over the city until the sun went down.

Lu Mingfei thought of his parents as Superman and Superwoman. Perhaps if the plane they were on crashed one day, they would finally appear before him, holding it up as they brought it safely to earth. Otherwise, they would always be busy saving the world, rather than doing anything for him, Lu Mingfei. Superhero parents were certainly something to brag about. In practice, though, they might as well not exist. He could barely remember what they looked like anymore. Only when he occasionally looked at an old family photograph could he faintly recall that man and woman, and their old house with its walls covered in Virginia creeper.

What interested his uncle and aunt more was the money his parents regularly sent from abroad. Thanks to that money, Lu Mingfei could attend an elite private high school. Thanks to it, his uncle and aunt could buy a small-engine BMW, his uncle could afford convincing counterfeit designer goods, and his aunt had money to lose at mahjong. Thanks to it, his cousin Lu Mingze had acquired the nickname "Crown Prince Ze" at school. The cousins attended the same high school. Lu Mingze not only had better grades, but dressed more carefully, and whenever girls joined him for a meal, he insisted on paying. His parents even dressed especially well for his parent-teacher conferences, leaving everyone with the impression that he was a child raised in a jar of honey.

If Lu Mingze hadn't been 160 centimeters tall and weighed 160 jin—eighty kilos—he probably would have found a girlfriend long ago.

And Lu Mingfei was merely "Lu Mingze's older cousin."

Lu Mingfei didn't particularly mind. Even his parents didn't care about him. How much could he ask of an uncle and aunt?

With both hands in his pockets, his head drooping and his eyes on the ground, Lu Mingfei went downstairs. He bought what his aunt wanted at the convenience store, then wandered over to the bookstall for the latest Fiction Illustrated.

His aunt thought Lu Mingze was clever, studious, ambitious, and especially devoted to literature. Even reading Fiction Illustrated became "our Mingze is studying" in her mouth. Every time a new issue appeared, she took it as another development in Chinese youth literature and hurried Lu Mingfei out to buy it so Mingze could keep up.

The old man at the newsstand downstairs thought Lu Mingfei was both melancholy and a bit of a freeloader, with a passion for literature. He was always buying Fiction Illustrated, though he never read it. Instead, he squatted beside the stand and read the latest Home Computers and Games for free, tossed it back, frankly declared that it was getting worse and worse, dusted off his pants, and left.

Lu Mingfei had a quietly sneaky streak. Lu Mingze was forever saying things like "in my house" and ordering his cousin to do this or that. Lu Mingfei always complied. Then, out of sheer pettiness, he visited Lu Mingze's secret Qzone page.

After reading some literature, Lu Mingze had adopted the pen name "Lonely Snake" and copied a great many sorrowful sentences onto his Qzone, alongside close-up selfies taken on his phone. Occasionally he uploaded pictures of his wrists smeared with red ink to look as if he had cut them, with poems more or less saying that without love he might as well die. Lu Mingfei knew his cousin's

romantic instincts were stirring. At school, any budding romance died the moment the girl saw him in daylight, so now he was hoping for a thunderous collision of souls on QQ.

Lu Mingfei registered a new QQ account under the name “Sunset’s Imprint.” He uploaded a photo of a cute, short-haired girl, entered his age as sixteen, and set his status to “Let your smiles and sorrows leave their imprint on my life.” While Lu Mingze was online at home, he slipped off to an internet café and struck up a conversation with Lonely Snake. Before long, Lu Mingze apparently felt that his little snake had finally found something delicious, and was more than happy to let his smiles and sorrows leave their imprint on a girl’s life. At home, he cheerfully hummed Shin’s “Parting Song” every day; on QQ, he kept asking to meet, ready to launch into an earth-shattering romance. Lu Mingfei agreed with absolute conviction, but always set the date for when his aunt would be dragging Lu Mingze off to piano lessons. Each time, the lovely girl slipped through his cousin’s fingers, leaving him bitterly distraught and lending his renditions of “Parting Song” a rather mournful note.

It was the happiest thing that had happened to Lu Mingfei lately.

That was the sort of person Lu Mingfei was. Not especially good, not particularly capable of doing anything bad. Almost eighteen, and he still had no idea where his future lay.

“Mingfei, I hear you’re going abroad to study,” the old newsstand owner said idly.

“Hardly. I’ve only applied. Who’d take me?” Lu Mingfei was squatting beside the stand, helping himself to a magazine.

“Studying abroad is good. Come back with a foreign degree, and you’ll make plenty of money.”

“I don’t want plenty of money. If I can’t get into college, I’ll help you run the stand. Just pay me enough to buy PS2 games.”

“No ambition. There’s no money in running a newsstand. I only do it because I’m old.”

Lu Mingfei rolled his eyes up toward the sunlight filtering through the green leaves. “Seems pretty nice. You can sit in the sun, space out when no one’s around, and watch pretty girls go by.”

The subject rather depressed him. He had applied to American universities, but certainly not because his grades were so dazzling that he stood much chance. Everyone had a different way of assessing his academic performance. His homeroom teacher said, “Lu Mingfei, were you born a lead weight? Do you have any idea how much you single-handedly drag down our class average?” His aunt told his uncle, “Mingze gets his good grades from my side of the family. Just look at your family’s genes. Hopeless!” Only Lu Mingze showed him any consideration, encouraging him on QQ: “Sunset! So what if your grades are bad? People like us have to walk our own path! As far as I’m concerned, you’re a wonderful girl!”

The idea of sending him abroad had come to his aunt in a flash of inspiration, and she had championed it single-handedly. She stood over him while he filled in the applications and generously paid the several-dozen-dollar fee for each school. She had her reasons. English was the only subject Lu Mingfei was decent at. When he tagged along with his English-obsessed classmates to take the TOEFL, he had enjoyed a spectacular stroke of dumb luck and scored well. With his grades, a first-tier Chinese university was a long shot. Skipping the national exam to study abroad was fashionable these days. They could try the applications, and if another stroke of dumb luck landed him an American acceptance letter, she would have something to show for all the money his parents had sent.

His aunt also had a second, "smaller" calculation. Lu Mingze's grades were a little better than Lu Mingfei's, but hardly outstanding. He couldn't get into the famous universities she was always talking about, like Tsinghua or Peking University. Skipping the exam to study abroad would be a respectable alternative. But college determined your whole life; she couldn't bear to let Mingze take that risk. After much thought, she seemed to recall some famous saying about how "every difficult path must first be trodden by the tough soles of the brave." Suddenly, Lu Mingfei struck her as very brave indeed. She would have him use those tough soles to tread a path for Lu Mingze. If he failed, no harm done. It would merely prove the path was blocked. Lu Mingfei could wait a year and take the entrance exam alongside his cousin.

Unfortunately, courage alone clearly couldn't open that difficult path. It was strewn with ankle-twisting stones. More than a dozen replies had already arrived, and their openings were much alike:

"Dear Applicant:

Thank you for your interest in our college. We regret to inform you…"

Several hundred dollars in application fees had bought his aunt nothing but repeated expressions of gratitude from Americans. Charity was proving painful. Lu Mingfei, meanwhile, was neither anxious nor impatient. He had the serene stillness of an old monk in meditation. He merely squeezed out a sorrowful expression whenever another rejection arrived, to keep his aunt company in her disappointment.

Only one university had yet to reply: the most highly ranked of the prestigious schools, the University of Chicago.

"Any mail for me?" Lu Mingfei poked his head around the gatehouse door, putting on an English accent. "Mingfei Lu."

"Yes. From America." The guard tossed out a letter.

Lu Mingfei felt the envelope. One thin sheet of paper. Definitely a rejection. Acceptance letters came with forms and informational materials, a whole thick stack. Thanking you for your application and regretting that you hadn't been admitted took only a single printed page.

He tore the envelope open. To his surprise, the letter was written in Chinese:

Dear Mr. Lu Mingfei:

Thank you for your interest in the University of Chicago. We regret to inform you that you have not been admitted.

However, as we often say, there is more than one road. The question is whether you are willing to take it.

Allow us first to introduce ourselves. Cassell College is a private institution located on the far outskirts of Chicago, Illinois, in the United States. We are affiliated with the University of Chicago and maintain extensive academic exchanges with it.

We have had the honor of receiving your application materials from the University of Chicago. Following a careful evaluation, we believe you meet Cassell College's admission requirements and would like to extend this invitation to you.

Please contact our Professor Guderian as soon as you receive this letter. He is currently on an academic visit to China and will arrange your interview.

Should you have any questions, please also contact Professor Guderian. I will assist him in providing any help you may require. My name is Norma Lawrence, secretary of Cassell College. It is a great pleasure to make your acquaintance.

Yours sincerely,

Norma

Lu Mingfei lowered the letter and felt his forehead, rather dazed.

It had begun perfectly normally, a standard rejection letter. How had everything changed after "However, as we often say, there is more than one road. The question is whether you are willing to take it"? Apparently, he was already on an interview list. Some of his high school classmates had successfully applied abroad, but an American professor traveling all this way to interview someone was a first. Lu Mingfei couldn't imagine what he had done to deserve it. He hadn't even contributed an application fee to this Cassell College.

Had Lu Mingze discovered Sunset's Imprint's true identity? Was this some elaborate revenge?

But the postmark on the envelope really was from Illinois, USA.

He tipped the envelope upside down. Apart from that one sheet of expensive paper, there was nothing else inside. That settled it: this had to be a scam. It told him to contact some Professor Guderian immediately, but didn't even give him a phone number. The thought actually made him feel a little better.

"Sign here." The guard tossed him another slip.

"You have to sign for letters?" Lu Mingfei asked, puzzled.

"A package came with it. You have to sign for that."

Still confused, Lu Mingfei signed and received a large FedEx envelope with something hard inside. He hesitated, tore it open, and tipped out… a phone.

An all-black N96.

Lu Mingfei felt he needed a moment to collect himself. He switched it on. The battery was actually more than half full. There was a single entry in the contacts: Professor Guderian.

"Definitely a con artist! And someone who lives in this complex! Only someone who knows us would know our situation!" His aunt slapped the letter and delivered her verdict with absolute certainty.

"But what con artist would spend that much? It's an N96! Even a gray-market one costs over four thousand yuan. An official one's over five thousand!" His uncle kept covering the black phone with fingerprints, like an old woman caressing a jade bangle passed down through the family.

His uncle was a man of taste. Lu Mingfei had once had the privilege of accompanying him to dinner and watching him set his phone down with his left hand and his lighter with his right, each landing on the table with just the right weight. In the course of conversation, he casually rolled up his sleeve to reveal a high-quality fake Montblanc watch bought in Guangzhou, winning unanimous praise for his taste. Lately, he had mentioned more than once to Lu Mingze that the new N96 was very "high-end" and suited him perfectly. But his aunt, who controlled the family finances, had given him a firm "No!"

"What Cassell College? It's got to be after our money! Affiliated with the University of Chicago, my foot. Chu Zihang, who ranked first in our school, went abroad last year to a college affiliated with

Chicago, too. One of his cousins is a university professor and already has a green card. Those colleges affiliated with famous universities are practically Ivy League. Even Americans can't get in!" Lu Mingze rarely took such an interest in his older cousin's future.

Lu Mingfei knew Chu Zihang was Lu Mingze's idol. When most of the other students were still wearing Nike and Adidas, Chu Zihang was already into brands like Burberry. He would loosely knot a Burberry scarf over a Diesel pullover and walk down the corridor with an expressionless face, and the whole school would call his look British. Once, two girls had been disciplined for clawing each other's faces over "whose Chu Zihang was," even though he had never so much as spoken to either of them.

Lu Mingze recounted this senior's exploits to Sunset's Imprint, declaring inspirationally that one day he would proudly prove to the whole school that he was every bit as good as Chu Zihang.

Lu Mingfei thought the real issue was all those flirtatious looks from girls across the grade. Lu Mingze cared more about "how to become a male lion ruling over a pride of lionesses" than about being as accomplished as Chu Zihang.

Lu Mingfei didn't envy Chu Zihang at all. Sometimes he thought, These people treat Chu Zihang like an idol, but none of them knows what he's doing in America. Maybe he's washing dishes in a restaurant. Without anyone teaching him, he had developed something of Ah Q's knack for consoling himself.

His Chinese teacher once held up his essay as a bad example and savaged it in class, saying it showed no imagination, only pessimism—just like its author, who had no ambition whatsoever.

Lu Mingfei had felt a little like standing up and saying that he had fantasies, too.

Once, after watching all three Matrix films back-to-back, he had suddenly felt that he must possess some extraordinary ability that had yet to be discovered. Like Neo, he was "the One." One day, a mysterious figure would come to uncover his power. Beneath everyone's blazing gaze, he would transform… and do something that shook the world.

But while delivering his criticism, the Chinese teacher had his lofty gaze fixed on the dozing students in the back rows and didn't spare Lu Mingfei so much as a sidelong glance. Lu Mingfei could only duck his head and abandon his explanation of his inner journey.

No one would discuss this magnificent idea with him, so he kept elaborating the details by himself. By senior year, the fantasy had acquired a full set of scenes. Whenever the school held its Lunar New Year gala, the pretty little piano prodigy Liu Miaomiao, who had passed the Grade Ten exam, would play onstage while the boys in her class danced around the piano in matching black formalwear. Lu Mingfei would sit in a forgotten corner with his chin in his hand, imagining that perhaps a helicopter would descend from the sky to collect him. Men in black suits and dark glasses would enter the hall with the icy efficiency of CIA agents in a movie and say in low voices, "Mr. Lu Mingfei, this is no time for a New Year's show. The organization needs you." They would put him in a black military uniform and a long trench coat, then escort him out under the eyes of his classmates. Outside, a black helicopter would roar, its great rotors whipping up a wind that cut across their faces like knives. Then the pretty Liu Miaomiao and all the dancing boys would stop and stare blankly at his retreating back.

The point of the story was never how he would save the world. It was the way everyone else would look at him as he left.

So. Damn. Cool.

Lu Mingfei knew perfectly well that the fantasy was only a way to pass the time. But he could find nothing about himself to be proud of. As far as he could tell, his future would be to attend some obscure college, fall in love there, then graduate, find a job, and rent an apartment. Perhaps when his parents occasionally remembered him, they would urge him to get married. So he would marry, have a child, and go to work every day.

And now, with this letter from America, something was actually going to disturb the stagnant pool of his life. Yet in the family meeting, he felt like an outsider, huddled in one corner of the sofa with his hands placed obediently on his knees, while the endless chatter of his uncle, aunt, and Lu Mingze filled the living room.

He stood and left. No one noticed the departure of the person at the center of it all. The other three kept arguing about whether the interview invitation was real. His aunt and Lu Mingze seemed rather shaken. If it was genuine, it was a spectacular stroke of dumb luck, the kind that didn't come to anyone once in ten years, and somehow it had come to Lu Mingfei. His aunt wasn't used to seeing this droopy boy suddenly perk up. How was Mingze supposed to outdo him now?

Lu Mingfei returned to his room, logged onto QQ, and stared at the baseball-cap girl's avatar. Still gray. Offline or invisible—either way, no message. He glanced at the clock on the wall. It had been eighteen hours since he had left Chen Wenwen a message asking whether she would attend the literary club activity tomorrow night.

Chen Wenwen didn't actually wear baseball caps. Her long hair was soft, fine, straight, and lovely; it needed no covering. Lu Mingfei had met her on the first day of school. She had arrived discreetly in a Passat, wearing a white cotton dress and white ankle socks edged with lace, a Hello Kitty clip in her long hair. The most dazzling girl in his class should have been Su Xiaoqiang, the "Little Celestial Princess." That day she had arrived in a Mercedes S500, dressed head to toe in DKNY, pride dancing in every glance. After waving goodbye to her coal-business father, she had gone to register, appraising the boys in her new class and expecting their admiring looks in return. But the boys were all stealing glances toward a corner by the window. Having finished her paperwork, Chen Wenwen sat there on a bench with a copy of Marguerite Duras's The Lover. Sunlight shone on her cotton dress and skin, making everything seem translucent.

After fifteen years of being the proudest girl around, the Little Celestial Princess had lost to a young literary type on her very first day of high school. She seethed. To make things worse, a tactless boy beside her pointed toward Chen Wenwen and said quietly, "I guess she's the prettiest girl in our new class."

When had the Little Celestial Princess ever suffered such humiliation? She stamped hard on his foot and turned away.

That boy was Lu Mingfei.

Really, Lu Mingfei was an honest person. He thought Chen Wenwen was prettier than the Little Celestial Princess, so he said so. How could he have known it would earn him a three-year feud? There had been seven or eight boys admiring Chen Wenwen, all thinking the same thing. The others simply understood the principle of "admiring in silence." Later, those boys formed a literary club with Chen Wenwen at its center. They met every week to read cold, sorrowful works of European and American literature and wrote reading responses for the Chinese teacher to mark. Lu Mingfei's uncle described

these as books for “middle-class white women” and couldn’t understand how someone as scatterbrained as Lu Mingfei had become a club officer.

To Lu Mingfei, Chen Wenwen was the first girl he had ever idolized, his model of the good girl who would make a happy home. At fifteen, he had thought there could be no greater happiness in the world than marrying her. He believed he had a tiny chance because she had personally invited him to join the club. As president, Chen Wenwen had invited only two members: Lu Mingfei and Zhao Menghua, whom the Little Celestial Princess was determined to have for herself. Zhao Menghua was easy to describe. Of everyone in the school, he was the likeliest to become “the next Chu Zihang.”

Zhao Menghua was applying abroad, too, and hadn’t received any offers either. Yet this muddleheaded Cassell College had sent an interview invitation to Lu Mingfei.

“Up for a match?” A big-faced cat avatar was flashing on QQ. The name was “Nono.” Lu Mingfei couldn’t remember adding this person, but he never turned down an invitation. Few enough people added him in the first place.

“Sure,” he replied absently.

Lu Mingfei was still using the pointing stick. Something was on his mind, he felt sluggish, and Nono sounded like a girl’s name. The genuinely good players in the channel were all middle-aged-guy types. But he soon discovered that this opponent was not only vicious but cunning. The moment his attention wandered, two Zerglings ambushed the Drone he had sent to scout. Losing one Drone was no big deal, but that neat little trap put him on his guard. He reinforced his base and sent six Zerglings to patrol nearby. It saved him. He spotted the enemy squad of Zerglings the instant they entered his territory. Their chance at a surprise attack gone, they had to pull back at once.

Lu Mingfei didn’t dare get careless again. He plugged in the mouse.

Only then did the real battle begin. Both sides upgraded their main forces from Zerglings to Hydralisks, and both simultaneously sent Mutalisks on air raids while their Hydralisks attacked, opening up a second front. By the time the Queens appeared, the fighting was white-hot. Each player had four bases. Mixed armies fought a savage tug-of-war over the open ground in the center, splashing sheets of blood across the battlefield. Sweat broke out on Lu Mingfei’s forehead. His hands danced over the keyboard as if he were playing the piano. It couldn’t be easy for the other player, either. The way they were pushing their micro was close to professional level. He had never faced anyone this strong. His competitive streak stirred, and he decided to risk upgrading his main base to tier three and bringing out the “three-horse team”: Devourers, Guardians, and Ultralisks. It was a fundamental shift in strategy. If his opponent hesitated even briefly and failed to attack while he was spending his resources on the upgrade, victory would be his.

The progress bar crept forward. His heart raced and his palms sweated. To bluff, he added a squad of Hydralisks and three Lurkers outside. If his opponent believed he was massing a large army and held back, she would have fallen for it. Those were all the troops he had. Every other resource had gone into the upgrade.

Almost there. Once the upgrade finished and the three-horse team appeared, he could advance through the air and on the ground, steadily picking off enemy bases one after another.

Lu Mingfei could see the first light of victory.

“You’re teching to tier three.” A line of text appeared at the bottom of the screen.

Lu Mingfei froze.

"Just quit. I've got four squads of Hydras and four of Lings, all with level-two attack and armor," Nono continued typing.

The progress bar was almost full, but Lu Mingfei could only type "GG." As she typed, Nono had shared her vision with him. Outside his main base, still upgrading to tier three, her army was massed. Once it attacked, the victory would be crushing.

Lu Mingfei left the game, returned to QQ, and told Nono, "Respect!"

Nono didn't answer. She left a grinning, big-toothed laughing emoji and logged off.

For the first time in his life, Lu Mingfei felt that someone had seen right through him. It was like a dearest friend, gone for years, coming back to find him. He sat there in a daze for a while, then clicked on Nono's profile. It was blank. He searched his memory and was certain he had never known a StarCraft player that good—much less a girl.

Chen Wenwen's avatar was bouncing in his contact list, but it was gray. She had come online and already left.

"Sure. See you the day after tomorrow." That was her message.

He had waited almost nineteen hours for those few words. But his low spirits seemed to evaporate. He jumped onto his bed, whistled, wiggled his hips, and beamed, completely forgetting that Nono had beaten him.

When Lu Mingze entered their shared bedroom, he looked his older cousin up and down and said impatiently, "Mom and Dad called that Professor Guderian. Your interview's at the Regent Hotel the day after tomorrow. They said you should get ready."

The following evening.

"Hey, Old Tang. Do you know what they ask in American college interviews?" Lu Mingfei typed on QQ.

"What? You got an interview?" Old Tang's panda avatar bounced frantically.

Old Tang was the only person Lu Mingfei could think of who might help. He lived in New York and was Chinese American. His last name was probably Tang. Everyone called him Old Tang, though he wasn't particularly old. Apparently, he had grown up in America, so his spoken Chinese wasn't very fluent, but he managed well enough typing online. Apart from occasionally thinking a little too highly of himself, Old Tang had no serious faults. His ambition in life was to become Indiana Jones.

"Yeah. Tomorrow morning. I've searched all over the internet, but I still don't know what they'll ask," Lu Mingfei admitted.

"Well… different schools ask completely different questions. NYU and Harvard, for example, are nothing alike."

"So which do you know better, Harvard or NYU?"

"Didn't I tell you I entered the workforce right after high school?" Old Tang posted a dejected panda face.

"'Entered the workforce'! Now that phrase shows real progress in your Chinese!"

"Enough, enough. Let's video chat. I'll coach your pronunciation," Old Tang said.

Lu Mingfei glanced at Lu Mingze, asleep on the other bed, and hesitated. “Keep it down, then. My cousin’s sleeping.”

“No problem.”

The call beeped twice and connected. A cheerful-looking guy with drooping eyebrows waved from the window and thundered, “Hey! Bro!”

Lu Mingfei nearly lunged forward and swallowed the speakers.

“Quiet! Quiet!” Waving frantically at Old Tang, he unplugged them and connected his headset.

“What’s the big deal?” Old Tang muttered. “My place is right by the elevated tracks. It’s noisy here. Where are you, anyway? Why so careful?”

“I live with my uncle and aunt,” Lu Mingfei whispered.

“Oh, oh.” Old Tang nodded and lowered his voice, his Chinese sliding off-key. “So if this application works out, you can move out on your own? You should’ve said! Leave that interview to me!”

“You’re a real friend, Old Tang.” Lu Mingfei gave him a thumbs-up.

“As the number-one StarCraft player in the channel, if I don’t look out for number two, what kind of big brother am I?” Old Tang said. “Ha ha!”

For a moment, Lu Mingfei was touched. He felt a little more confident about tomorrow. He had drifted around all day, watched the sunset from the roof as usual, and still had no idea what to do. No one could tell him what an American college interview was like. The other applicants were probably having their pronunciation corrected word by word by tutors or parents. But Lu Mingfei had no one to help. After wandering around online for ages, he had happened to see Old Tang’s avatar bouncing and messaged him on the off chance. He didn’t even know Old Tang that well.

So there was someone, in some corner of the world he hadn’t thought of, who could help him after all. Someone with a baffling determination to play big brother and look after him.

Loyalty. This was loyalty!

“Come to think of it, I lost both my parents, too,” Old Tang went on with a sigh. “It’s hard getting by in America, you know, especially for people like us with both parents gone. At least I can get welfare…”

“Pah, pah, pah! Who lost both their parents? My mom and dad are just away from home!” Lu Mingfei spat furiously at him.

“Oh, oh. Saw-ree, saw-ree. Got the wrong end of the stick and the wrong end of the feelings.” Old Tang repeatedly clasped his hands in apology on the screen.

“Come on, man. Can you stop mangling Chinese? And what’s ‘saw-ree’? It’s ‘sorry,’ all right? Aren’t you supposed to be coaching my accent?” Lu Mingfei had no answer for his complete lack of a filter.

“Right, right. And once we’re done, we’ve got a few more matches to play. Come on, let’s start!” Old Tang cleared his throat. “The most common opening question is, why did you apply to our school? ‘Why did you apply this college, please show me some reason?’”

“But I didn’t apply…”

"Come on! No talking back. Repeat after me! I'm taking responsibility for your future, bro! 'The great faculty is the key reason, and your college have very good research atmosphere…'"

"'The great faculty is the key reason, and your college have very good research atmosphere…'" Lu Mingfei repeated each sound after Old Tang.

Night deepened. The small southern city grew still. Streetlights illuminated empty roads. Most apartment lights were out; only a few scattered windows remained bright. Behind one of them, a boy repeated the same sentences over and over in his indistinct pronunciation, cramming at the last minute. Tens of thousands of miles away, a guy eating yogurt shouted "No, no, no!" at every sound he got wrong.

Lu Mingze rolled his eyes, glanced at Lu Mingfei, grunted impatiently, stuffed both hands over his ears, and turned over.

The third morning. The Regent Hotel.

It was the most luxurious hotel in the city, part of a global five-star chain. Lu Mingfei knew the place because his uncle loved drinking tea and chatting with friends in its lobby, having the waiters refill the pot until the strong tea became plain water. It cost little that way, while allowing him the satisfaction of enjoying world-class service.

Lu Mingfei had never been through its glass doors. Now he looked around with eyes red from staying up all night.

This hotel is fucking luxurious! American schools are fucking rich! he marveled.

He sat outside a conference room on the executive floor. There were exactly seventeen chairs, one for each of the seventeen applicants. No one had asked for identification. As he had cautiously stepped through the hotel entrance, an attendant had smiled and asked, "Are you here for the Cassell College interview? Please follow me to the executive floor." Then a pretty young woman in a skirt suit and ten-centimeter heels had led him to this room, where he found familiar faces.

Chen Wenwen, Su Xiaoqiang, Zhao Menghua, and Liu Miaomiao were all there. So were others from his school whose faces he knew but whose names he couldn't remember, along with some he had never seen.

"Lu Mingfei?" Everyone who knew him sounded equally astonished, as though his presence here were an extraordinary event.

He could only wave the letter in his hand and grin. "I'm here for…" He swallowed. "…an interview, too."

Then he slunk to the last chair. A form and a pencil lay on it. The form asked for his name, age, and similar details. He filled it in while his eyes darted around.

Things looked utterly hopeless. Everyone had prepared, and every one of them was formidable. Zhao Menghua's pronunciation went without saying: his tutor was American. So did Su Xiaoqiang's: she had spent a year in America during middle school. Even the usually casual Chen Wenwen had coordinated her outfit carefully: a navy skirt suit, white lace-edged socks, flat black shoes, and a white neck scarf. She had replaced her hair clip with one made of mother-of-pearl. She looked like one of those British aristocrats' children in their school uniforms on television.

Lu Mingfei scratched his head and sighed.

"She looks so nice." Having lost interest in comparing their chances, he turned to admire Chen Wenwen.

An attendant brought refreshments: a croissant and a glass of hot milk. Lu Mingfei ate the bread, drank the milk, and, with the problem of basic survival solved, went back to watching Chen Wenwen. After a while, a thought flashed through his head… What if a stroke of dumb luck got him through, and he could study abroad with her?

He looked up at the ceiling and suddenly gave two foolish chuckles, startling the people around him.

"Lu Mingfei, quiet. The interviewers are here. They're inside." Chen Wenwen covered her mouth as she whispered, pointing toward the inner conference room.

"Are you ready?" Beaming, he leaned over to make conversation. It was a pointless question. He only wanted to hear her speak.

"I'm not very confident." Chen Wenwen glanced at Su Xiaoqiang and Zhao Menghua, then lowered her eyes, looking a little discouraged. "My spoken English isn't as good as theirs…"

"You'll be fine! I think your English is really…" Lu Mingfei began.

"Is Liu Miaomiao here?" The inner door opened and a tall, thin young man stepped out, speaking fluent Chinese and looking as unmistakably Chinese as anyone could. He wore a fitted dark-green suit, finely edged in silver at the collar. Gold buttons and cuffs gleamed, and a badge embroidered in silver thread rested on his chest. It looked like a school uniform, but Lu Mingfei had never seen one so exquisitely tailored.

The pretty pianist shot to her feet, her voice trembling slightly. "Here!"

"I'm Ye Sheng, one of your interviewers. Please come with me." The young man smiled, showing white teeth.

Liu Miaomiao walked gracefully inside with Ye Sheng. The door closed. The sixteen people left outside looked at one another, none able to hide their nerves.

"Hey, did you look up this Cassell College's website?" Zhao Menghua glanced at Su Xiaoqiang and Chen Wenwen, lowering his voice. "Apparently, it's a really prestigious school. Lots of Harvard professors have gone over to teach there!"

"Yes." Chen Wenwen nodded. "But I got an interview invitation without even applying."

"Prestigious schools are like that, aren't they? They don't care about application fees. Just your ability," Zhao Menghua said.

"If they only care about ability, how did someone like that sneak in?" Su Xiaoqiang gave Lu Mingfei a sidelong look.

Lu Mingfei shrugged his shoulders with the shameless indifference of someone who had nothing left to lose.

"I wonder how many they'll admit," Chen Wenwen whispered.

"One or two would be plenty!" Su Xiaoqiang said. "Haven't you heard? Harvard only admits a few undergraduates from China each year."

Lu Mingfei's heart sank. He had no idea how many Chinese students Harvard admitted annually, but if there were only a handful in a country this huge, the odds of that particular stroke of dumb luck landing on him were microscopic. Eight-tenths of his hard-won confidence vanished.

"Well, I'm just here to try. I don't have much hope," Chen Wenwen said softly.

"None of us does," Zhao Menghua said to comfort her.

"I don't care." Su Xiaoqiang was as haughty as ever. "If they don't take me, I'll go to Stanford. My dad has connections!"

The door opened, and Ye Sheng made a courteous gesture. Liu Miaomiao came out, turning back to thank him. She was clearly trying not to look disappointed, but the disappointment was written honestly across her face.

The pretty pianist hadn't even lasted ten minutes! Her eyes a little red, Liu Miaomiao returned to her chair, took her bag, and headed straight out.

"Su Xiaoqiang," Ye Sheng said.

The Little Celestial Princess sprang up, too, her lovely eyes wide, her teeth chattering.

Watching her follow Ye Sheng inside on stiff legs, Lu Mingfei let out a "Ha!"

"Don't laugh at her. Aren't you scared?" Chen Wenwen gave his shoulder a push.

"I'm not scared. What have I got to be scared of? I'm just here for the ride." He laced his hands behind his head and sprawled across the chair.

When the Little Celestial Princess came out, her steps were stiffer than when she had gone in. Her expression was more angry than disappointed or dejected. Ye Sheng smiled politely behind her. She turned and shot him a furious look. Then he called Zhao Menghua inside.

"What kind of college is this? They're making fools of us!" Su Xiaoqiang turned and left.

Lu Mingfei and Chen Wenwen exchanged a baffled look. The Little Celestial Princess had done worse than Liu Miaomiao. She had lasted perhaps five minutes.

Inside, the interviewer seemed less interested in conducting interviews than in practicing swordplay, cutting people down faster and faster. Zhao Menghua, reputed to have the best spoken English in the senior class, didn't last even three minutes. When he was escorted out, his eyes were blank.

"Chen Wenwen," Ye Sheng said.

"Good luck!" Lu Mingfei called softly after her.

She glanced back at him and nodded gently.

Seconds and minutes passed. Everyone outside remained silent. Lu Mingfei could hear his own heart pounding. He was a little afraid—afraid that Chen Wenwen would emerge with that same disappointed face.

She lasted fifteen minutes. When she came out, her face showed nothing. She kept her head down, looking at the tips of her shoes.

"How was it? How was it?" Lu Mingfei hurried over.

Chen Wenwen hesitated, then secretly beckoned him closer. "They'll ask…"

Delighted, Lu Mingfei was just about to lean in when Ye Sheng said, "Lu Mingfei."

He froze and turned. Ye Sheng was beckoning. "Lu Mingfei, you're next."

Strange. He had never met Ye Sheng. Had the man recognized him instantly from the tiny photograph on his University of Chicago application? Lu Mingfei was curious.

He followed Ye Sheng into the conference room. It was almost empty. At a vast table that could seat dozens sat just one girl, smiling sweetly. She wore the same uniform as Ye Sheng, only in a skirt suit, with a rose-red lace scarf tucked into her collar.

"My name is Aki Sakatoku. I'm also one of your interviewers." The girl stood and bowed to Lu Mingfei in the unmistakably Japanese manner.

"Oh-high-yo." Without thinking, Lu Mingfei bowed back.

After so many years shut away at home, playing countless PS2 games and watching endless anime, he did know a couple of lines of Japanese dialogue.

"Ohayō." Aki Sakatoku covered her mouth and laughed softly, correcting the Henan accent he had somehow given his Japanese. Her smile had an older sister's warmth.

Looks like I've made a good first impression, Lu Mingfei thought happily.

Ye Sheng sat beside Aki Sakatoku, opened his notebook, and looked at him. "Then let's begin."

Lu Mingfei nodded and took a deep breath, settling it deep in his belly. He had trained all night. Now came the test!

"Do you believe in aliens?" Aki Sakatoku asked gently.

He froze for an instant. Then he felt… a nuclear bomb go off inside his head… mushroom clouds everywhere, and nothing else at all.

What was happening? Surely the first question was supposed to be "Please introduce yourself" or "Why did you apply to our school?"

The answer to the first one was, "My name is Mingfei Lu, a Chinese high school student, I like online computer game and panda…"

The answer to the second was, "The great faculty is the key reason, and your college have very good research atmosphere…"

Old Tang had enthusiastically polished those answers. Lu Mingfei had then recited them seventy or eighty times before finally getting them down.

But this… What was this about aliens?

All that preparation… Completely useless!

Lu Mingfei's eyes went as round as brass bells, and his head slowly drooped. This was the kind of loser he was. His luck was always spectacularly rotten. He was the guy who penciled a desk full of formulas before an exam, only for the teacher to make everyone swap seats; who finally managed a peek at the answer sheet next to him, only to discover that his neighbor had Test A and he had Test B… As a born loser, he should have had the courage to believe in his fate instead of putting up a pointless struggle.

"Sure. I believe in aliens," he said. Suddenly, he felt Zhao Menghua was a hero for having lasted three minutes.

"Really?" Aki Sakatoku's expression was mild, offering no sign of approval or disapproval. "Why do you believe in them?"

Hell, why did he believe? Believing was just believing. Nobody in the world could prove they had seen an alien, and yet some people believed and others didn't. It was like asking why you liked the girl at the next desk in the white cotton dress. You could come up with thousands of reasons, but the real

one was simply that you didn't know what was happening: whenever you saw her, your heart raced; you cared terribly about what she said and remembered everything to do with her. And so you knew you liked her. Why? There was no reason, Lu Mingfei thought.

"I wander around on the roof at night a lot. Look at the stars when I've got nothing to do," he said.

"Yes. Good. Looks at the stars in his spare time." Aki Sakatoku took very earnest notes.

Lu Mingfei couldn't understand her seriousness. You would have thought he was China's foreign minister, solemnly delivering a mass of diplomatic language that needed to be carefully recorded.

"If you look at the stars, you start thinking. If there aren't any aliens, the universe is so huge, tens of billions of light-years across, and a beam of light has to travel tens of billions of years to get from one end to the other, passing through so many galaxies. But the only time it meets people is here on Earth. It takes less than a second for light to pass Earth, so in tens of billions of years, there's only one second when it encounters anyone. That would be the strange thing, wouldn't it?" he said.

"Loneliness? Were you implying that the light is lonely?" Ye Sheng interjected.

Lu Mingfei scratched his head. He hadn't actually been implying anything, but his answer seemed to have acquired a little depth. So he nodded, tacitly allowing Ye Sheng to see him as a lonely kid.

"Second question. Do you believe in superpowers?" Aki Sakatoku asked.

"Sure," Lu Mingfei said. "Absolutely."

Once he stopped caring, the questions weren't difficult at all. If superpowers didn't exist, then Jotaro Kujo's Star Platinum wouldn't exist, nor Luffy's Gum-Gum Fruit, and Hiei's Dragon of the Darkness Flame would naturally be fake, too. Then the main things left in the world would be the Montblanc watches his uncle never stopped mentioning and the soaring housing prices his aunt complained about more every day. His own future would be getting up every morning to catch a bus to work, paying the mortgage with his salary at the end of each month, and tiptoeing around his mother-in-law's home on weekends, trying to please her… assuming any girl would marry him.

So in Lu Mingfei's world, superpowers simply had to exist.

"And why do you believe in them?" Aki Sakatoku watched him with an encouraging smile.

"I believe… because I believe. Same as aliens," he said.

He really couldn't give her the actual reason. He could hardly say, "I love Jotaro Kujo's Star Platinum, and I want it to be real."

"A badass life needs no explanation," Ye Sheng said.

Lu Mingfei stared. Why had the interviewer suddenly come out with an internet catchphrase?

He's probably making fun of me, he thought.

"Third question. Do you think the foundation of human existence is idealist—mind and soul—or materialist—matter and the physical body?" Aki Sakatoku asked.

Lu Mingfei's mind went blank on the spot.

Had these college interviewers fried their brains? Why was question three so different from the first two? This was high school politics class, wasn't it? Analyzing materialism and idealism. But he had forgotten every bit of that after passing the graduation exam!

His face reddened, and he gulped air. Who knew how many people this question had taken down? But he had to get through it!

He let out a long breath, rolled his eyes, and stuck out his tongue.

"Er… what does sticking out your tongue mean?" Ye Sheng gave Aki Sakatoku a hesitant look.

"I don't know." Lu Mingfei sighed. "The question's too deep. I really can't answer it. Can I… give up?"

Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku were silent for a moment, then nodded. "Of course. Thank you for your interest in Cassell College."

Ye Sheng stood. "I'll show you out."

Lu Mingfei had lasted one minute and thirty seconds, setting a new record for the quickest execution.

Chen Wenwen was waiting outside with her bag. Seeing him emerge, she hurried over. "Why are you out so soon?"

"The politics question got me…" His head drooped. "I'm not as good as you guys. How many did you answer?"

"The politics question got me, too. My answer was a mess. They said I hadn't passed." Chen Wenwen lowered her head.

"But you were in there fifteen minutes!" he said, startled.

"I talked about flying saucers for fifteen minutes…" she whispered.

"Huh?" He stared at her.

Then, in an instant, joy welled up inside him. He reached out and patted her head. "It's fine, it's fine! With questions from a bunch of lunatics like that, anyone who passed would have to be a lunatic, too!"

She raised her head, a hint of a smile appearing on her downcast face. Lu Mingfei's heart bloomed. It felt like the greatest reward the day could have given him.

What did it matter if he couldn't go abroad? Chen Wenwen wasn't going either!

Late at night, Ye Sheng sat at the conference table, going through the applications once more.

He looked up at Aki Sakatoku beside him. "Where's that little girl? Haven't seen her all day. She didn't even show up for the interviews. She's supposed to be an interviewer, too."

"Off having fun somewhere. That's why she came along in the first place, isn't it?" Aki Sakatoku shrugged. "What can you do? She's still just a little girl."

"How did the interviews go?" The door opened, and someone hurried in carrying a briefcase. "I booked a red-eye and came straight here after landing."

It was an elderly man, travel-worn, with thick glasses perched on his nose. His gray hair was a fluffy mess, not because he had permed it, but because he hadn't combed it in who knew how long. His suit was shabby, his trousers baggy.

"Professor Guderian." Ye Sheng stood. "We interviewed seventeen students in all…"

"Don't waste time! I'm asking about Lu Mingfei! I only care about Lu Mingfei!" Professor Guderian looked as anxious as a parent rather than an interviewer. "Tell me—how did he answer?" The old fellow of German descent spoke remarkably fluent Chinese.

Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku exchanged a glance. He turned to the page of notes on Lu Mingfei, hesitated, then shook his head.

"He left after just a minute and a half," Ye Sheng said.

"The best students always hand in their papers first!" Professor Guderian was delighted.

"Well… for question one, he said he believed in aliens because without them, humanity would be rather lonely in the universe…" Ye Sheng smiled helplessly.

"What a wonderful answer! I'm genuinely moved!" Professor Guderian clicked his tongue in admiration. "That's Lu Mingfei for you!"

"It… it's that good?" Ye Sheng stared. "For question two, he believed in superpowers as well, but couldn't give a reason…"

"Perfect!" Professor Guderian declared.

"That's… a perfect answer? That's the answer… the college had in mind?" Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku looked at one another.

"Let me explain!" Professor Guderian said. "In question one, not only did he say he believed in aliens, he introduced the crucial concept of loneliness. Loneliness is what binds our people together! That one word goes straight to the heart of the question. Aliens are a metaphor for the difference between our kind and ordinary people. For question two, belief requires absolutely no reason. What we mean by belief is an innate sense of trust that comes from within. If he had invented reasons for his trust, he would have lost points. How did he answer question three?"

"I don't know…" Aki Sakatoku touched her forehead. "I mean, he said he didn't know…"

Professor Guderian raised his head and drew a deep breath. "If I didn't know how extraordinary his bloodline was, I'd think he'd peeked at the answers."

"Don't tell me the answer is… 'I don't know'?" Ye Sheng scratched his head.

"The answer is 'I don't know'! His bloodline determines his worldview. A person straddling two races also stands somewhere between idealism and materialism in his understanding of the world. That demonstrates his potential," Professor Guderian said loudly. "Any student with real potential is bound to feel precisely that uncertainty about the world!"

"Professor Guderian, aren't you simply… playing favorites?" Aki Sakatoku asked with a wry smile.

Professor Guderian paused, then spread his hands. "Well… a little… But I really do think he answered rather well…"

"I understand that the college makes allowances for students with exceptional bloodlines. But favoritism this blatant… isn't it a bit much?" Ye Sheng shook his head. "If that's how it is, why interview anyone at all?"

"You don't understand. We haven't had an S-rank candidate like this in decades. If we turn in an interview report that says he failed… the principal won't let us off either!"

Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku exchanged a look. "He really is… S-rank?"

"Yes. It's been checked again and again. Of all the candidates, he's rated S. The only S! These interviews were, in fact, arranged for him alone!" Professor Guderian nodded and lowered his voice. "This is classified at the college's highest level. That's why you weren't told before setting out."

Silence.

"Ah!" Aki suddenly cried.

Professor Guderian clutched his chest. "Why are you shrieking all of a sudden?"

"I just remembered something awful. Your favorite S-rank student… He seemed extremely disappointed with his answers. So after saying 'I don't know,' he said he was giving up and walked straight out." Aki and Ye Sheng looked at each other.

"But he answered so well! Why would he give up?" Professor Guderian looked ready to leap into the air.

"With those questions and those answers…" Ye Sheng shrugged with a wry smile. "You might be the only person who thinks he did well."

"We must fix this! We have to get him back! I'll call his family!" Professor Guderian patted himself all over, searching for his phone.

Ye Sheng scratched his head and sighed. "Let me call… You'll frighten his family like this. They'll think you're up to something."

Three in the morning. In the dead silence, a telephone rang down the hallway of Lu Mingfei's home.

His aunt jolted upright from sleep and turned toward the phone on the nightstand, which was ringing so merrily it almost seemed to be jumping up and down.

"Did someone in your family die? Calling in the middle of the night!" She snatched it up and shouted furiously.

Soon, the anger left her face. She couldn't say a word. Her husband sat up in bed and saw his wife, hair disheveled, eyes vacant, as though she had been struck by lightning.

The ringing next door woke Lu Mingze, too. He turned toward the other bed and saw his older cousin licking his lips in his sleep, making happy little piglike grunts.

The following morning. The Regent Hotel.

The whole family had turned out for the VIP dining lounge on the ninth-floor executive level. His uncle, in an immaculate suit, stuck out his belly and lectured the boys about behaving properly in a high-class place and not constantly touching the cutlery. His aunt looked around, clicking her tongue in admiration. A high-class hotel really was high-class.

"Mr. Lu Mingfei? Green tea or dark tea?" A neatly dressed waiter approached and addressed Lu Mingfei, sandwiched between his uncle and aunt.

"What are the prices?" His uncle displayed the air of a man accustomed to fine establishments.

"Everything is complimentary for guests in the presidential suite. That is the suite Professor Guderian has booked."

"American schools really are rich!" His aunt acquired an instant respect for Cassell College.

With a ding, the express elevator opened. A burly, gray-haired old man strode toward their table by the window, Ye Sheng on his left and Aki Sakatoku on his right. Flanked by the handsome young man and lovely young woman like a hunter with hound and hawk, he cut a commanding figure. Without a word of preamble, he seized Lu Mingfei's hand. "Hello, Lu Mingfei!"

"Hello… Professor… Guderian?" Lu Mingfei was embarrassed by this overwhelming enthusiasm. "Your Chinese is really good."

Professor Guderian's eyes lit up. He scratched his head happily. "Is it that good? I learned from CCTV's evening news. We promote Chinese throughout the college. Everyone knows China is going to become the most prosperous place in the world!" He looked at Lu Mingfei, eyes shining, openly trying to win him over. "Join us. You won't need English. Every student speaks Chinese."

Lu Mingfei blinked. What did that mean? Chinese? No need for English? In a life with so few bright spots, that TOEFL score was about the only thing he had to show. If even his one bright spot didn't matter, what did Cassell College see in him? Professor Guderian, whom he had just met, looked positively overjoyed.

"Hello, Professor Gu. I'm Lu Mingfei's uncle." Unable to bear being left out, his uncle squeezed between them.

Unable to remember the whole name Guderian, he had very cleverly shortened it to Professor Gu.

"You two really don't look alike!" Professor Guderian shook his hand.

Now it was his uncle's turn to be embarrassed. For all his grandeur and his presidential suite, this Professor Guderian seemed a little out of touch.

Behind him, Ye Sheng tugged his sleeve. The three of them sat across the table.

"Let's have breakfast." Professor Guderian took his fork in his left hand and knife in his right, never taking his eyes off Lu Mingfei.

Lu Mingfei felt he was being watched with the anticipation of a gourmet regarding a roast chicken.

The expensive breakfast included salmon rolls and freshly squeezed lemon juice, and the solid-silver cutlery was decidedly impressive. It immediately banished his uncle's displeasure. After all, there was nothing shameful about Lu Mingfei not looking like him. Hosts and guests alike were happy.

Professor Guderian praised Lu Mingfei's outstanding interview performance. His uncle was delighted to say that you could tell at a glance Cassell College was an American school for the elite. Chinese universities simply couldn't compare with such style.

Ye Sheng had prepared thoroughly. He produced a copy of the college's official registration with the U.S. Department of Education for his aunt to inspect, followed by a photo album. This was the library; this was the sports center; this was the concert hall. The campus in the pictures was elegant and old-fashioned, like a completely renovated castle.

One photo showed Ye Sheng himself on a windsurfing board, a sea of sails competing behind him. It was the annual college windsurfing race, he explained. Cassell had beaten the University of Chicago three years running.

His aunt was won over, too. She exclaimed that their Mingfei must have earned extraordinary blessings in a previous life to attend such a school.

Lu Mingfei had a strange feeling. It was like marrying off a daughter. He was the daughter who cost money at home but would bring in a bride-price if married out. The groom's family was eager, and the bride's family was more than happy to oblige.

He worked up his courage. "Professor Guderian… what does your college see in me?"

"Your overall qualities! Your enormous potential!" The professor didn't look remotely as though he were joking. "We think so highly of you that we want not only to admit you, but to give you a scholarship. I've decided to allocate thirty-six thousand U.S. dollars a year from the scholarship fund under my name. Enough to see you through all four years!"

His uncle and aunt gasped together.

"Professor Gu… there aren't… any conditions attached, are there? Like having to pay it back afterward… We should be clear about that first." His uncle sensed something wrong.

"No! Absolutely not! A scholarship is a reward for your nephew, because he is outstanding!" Professor Guderian declared with righteous conviction.

"That sounds fake." His uncle shook his head.

"Of course, there are other reasons. Lu Mingfei's parents happen to be honorary alumni, and they have made donations to the college. All other things being equal, we give preference to alumni's children."

Lu Mingfei looked up at once. It felt as though a small rabbit were jumping in his chest. He had forgotten how long it had been since he had heard any real news of his parents. His mother's letters only told him to take care of himself and study hard, the same thing every time. Sometimes he felt those letters were just a way of brushing him off, and his parents no longer cared about him at all.

"They care about you very much," Professor Guderian said. "I haven't met them myself, but I hear they've been working on a very important research project, traveling all over the world these past years. I have a photograph of them here. Oh, and a letter your mother wrote to the college about you."

He took a photograph from his pocket and placed it before Lu Mingfei. It showed a summer garden. In the distance was what looked like Cassell College in the sunset. Closer were walls of climbing greenery, a deep, luminous green. A man and a woman walked hand in hand among them. The man wore a loose white shirt, wide-legged trousers, and wooden sandals. The woman wore a plain white cotton house dress.

Lu Mingfei reached out and gently touched the two faces. That handsome man and beautiful woman were his parents, but they were so far away, in some corner of the world he could never reach. His nose began to sting. In the photograph, they were looking into each other's faces, smiling warmly. Clearly, it was their own little world for two. They had probably forgotten that, between them, they had once made a child.

His aunt offered a concise assessment. "Two people their age, still so romantic!"

Professor Guderian passed him a letter next. It was short and printed out, probably an email:

Dear Principal Anjou:

It has been a long time since we were in touch. I hope you are as well as ever.

We probably will not be able to meet for quite some time. There have been new developments in our research, and we cannot leave.

There is something I would like to ask of you. My son Lu Mingfei is now eighteen. He is a clever child. His grades may not be especially good, but we both believe he can accomplish something in scholarship. If possible, please help him gain admission to Cassell College.

Since I cannot tell him in person, please pass on a message for me: his mother and father love him.

Yours sincerely,

Qiao Weini

Lu Mingfei read in silence. For a long time, he said nothing.

Professor Guderian cleared his throat. Then, looking straight into Lu Mingfei's eyes, he said with immense tenderness and slightly imperfect pronunciation, "Mingfei, Mommy and Daddy love you."

Lu Mingfei stared, completely stunned.

"The principal insisted that I pass on your parents' message. He cares about you very much, too," Professor Guderian said.

The clumsy delivery was too much for Lu Mingze, who burst out laughing. His parents couldn't keep straight faces either. In the letter, Qiao Weini's words were so tender they could have brought tears to your eyes. Spoken by a gray-haired, gray-bearded Professor Guderian with his clueless expression, they acquired an irresistibly comic incongruity. Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku shook their heads with helpless smiles. The professor reached out and gave Lu Mingfei a hearty pat on the shoulder.

The atmosphere at the table suddenly grew much warmer.

"I'm going to the restroom." Lu Mingfei stood.

He leaned his back against the restroom door and stood quietly for a while. Tears began to run silently down his face.

They had all laughed, but he couldn't see anything funny about it.

It should have been moving. Through all those years, all the way to eighteen, hardly anyone had cared what he thought or what he did. Time after time, he had walked home from school and watched his classmates get picked up, one by one. Looking back at the dust those cars left behind, he had sometimes thought that perhaps no one in this world loved him at all.

"Mingfei, Mommy and Daddy love you."

Lu Mingfei believed it. On paper, the words hadn't really made him feel anything. But when Professor Guderian said them aloud, suddenly he believed.

"I love you." Words like that had to be spoken. Saying them was different from writing them on paper. Especially to a drooping little kid starved of love.

He knew he was being rather stupid, but he couldn't help the sadness. He could only hide in the restroom. He slid down against the door and squatted, tears streaming, drawing circles on the tiles. He would wait until the tears stopped, then go out and say he had needed to take a dump.

Just then, a pair of running shoes with a muted purple pattern appeared before him.

He looked up in surprise. A girl stood there. From the bottom up: running shoes, close-fitting jeans, a little white tank top beneath a cropped blue-striped shirt, and a baseball cap perched on her head.

Something seemed wrong. He couldn't work out what. He blinked.

The tall, radiant girl looked down at him sidelong. Sterling-silver four-leaf-clover earrings swayed at her ears, their tiny diamonds flashing painfully bright.

"This is the ladies' room," she informed him at her leisure.

Lu Mingfei returned to the table with his head hanging. The pretty, tall girl followed, her face cold.

"Oh? Nono, I thought you'd gone out to have fun." Professor Guderian stood. "Let me introduce Chen Motong, a second-year student of Chinese descent and our student interviewer for this visit. This is your new schoolmate, Lu Mingfei."

"Nono?" Lu Mingfei paused. The name sounded familiar.

"I ate at a street-food stall last night, and my stomach's been a little upset. I've been in the restroom." Chen Motong sat beside Aki Sakatoku.

"Why didn't you invite me? I'd love to try one of those things called street-food stalls." Professor Guderian sounded disappointed. "I've heard about them on the news."

"In a report about recycled gutter oil, was it?" Chen Motong picked up her knife and fork and stole the last salmon roll from Ye Sheng's plate.

"I have one left, too. You can have it." Aki Sakatoku forked hers onto Chen Motong's plate as well.

"You work together so well. Just like a married couple. Why haven't you gotten married yet?" Chen Motong mumbled around a mouthful of salmon roll.

Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku looked at each other, both a little helpless and a little embarrassed.

Lu Mingfei was grateful that the girl hadn't exposed his humiliation. But as soon as she joined them, the warm family atmosphere evaporated. Sitting closest to the window, Chen Motong looked at no one and buttered her bread by herself. In the sunlight, her long hair glowed a deep red, like wine.

He had never met a girl like her. She wasn't like Su Xiaoqiang, who cared so much about how others saw her. Nor was she like the delicate, quiet Chen Wenwen, who avoided people's eyes. Chen Motong looked like a proud princess who didn't care about anything. Even when she looked straight at you, you felt that she wasn't really seeing you at all.

His uncle was stealing looks at her wrist. Lu Mingfei knew what he was looking at: the silver, diamond-set Omega watch.

"Mind if I eat yours, too?" Chen Motong wiped her mouth with a napkin and fixed her eyes on Lu Mingfei.

He could only nod. What a rare honor: such a proud princess actually looking into his eyes and speaking to him… for the sake of a salmon roll.

"Nono, some manners. Look after our new student," Professor Guderian said.

"He has no appetite." She glanced at Lu Mingfei. "Look how distracted he is. He could probably even walk into the wrong restroom."

His heart gave a jolt. Chen Motong stuck out her tongue and took his entire breakfast plate.

"Oh? Really? Mingfei, is there anything you're still worried about?" Professor Guderian looked into his eyes. "An opportunity to attend Cassell College is extremely rare. You must treasure it!"

"I… I still need to think." He lowered his head.

His uncle, aunt, and Lu Mingze were dumbfounded. Had something short-circuited in his brain? A free meal had fallen from the sky. What was there to think about? Other people couldn't get such an opportunity however hard they begged. He should just open his mouth and catch it.

Professor Guderian grew anxious. "If there are any conditions we can meet, just name them!"

"No." Lu Mingfei shook his head. "I…"

"It's his first love." Chen Motong twirled her fork, Lu Mingfei's salmon roll speared on it. "Let me think. White… long hair… very gentle… quiet… a hundred sixty-five centimeters tall… a girl in his class. Yes, more or less. Someone like that."

She turned to the window and chewed as though no one else existed.

Lu Mingfei shuddered. Lu Mingze's ears pricked up. His uncle and aunt gave him suspicious looks. The table fell silent. The only sound, extraordinarily clear, was Chen Motong chewing his salmon roll.

"Nono, stop it," Aki Sakatoku said.

"Just kidding." Chen Motong pushed away the empty plate, showed her bright white teeth, and gave Lu Mingfei a beautiful, unfriendly smile. "We hardly know each other. We only met today, didn't we? Even if he had a first love, how would I know who she was?"

Everyone exhaled together. Professor Guderian looked immensely relieved.

"Our Mingfei wouldn't get involved with girls. Would you, Mingfei?" His aunt was reassured. He hadn't secretly found a girlfriend behind her back, which meant her authority in the household remained intact. Besides, she rather doubted anyone could be blind enough to fall for him. The girls at his school were all well-brought-up young ladies. What chance did he have?

"Who'd want me?" Lu Mingfei chewed and chewed a stalk of asparagus. As long as his mouth kept moving, he didn't have to fake an expression.

"A student's priority should be studying," his uncle said.

"You're teching to tier three," Chen Motong suddenly said.

His heart trembled. The asparagus fell onto his plate.

Late at night, in the quiet, Lu Mingfei sat at his laptop with two things open: QQ and StarCraft.

His uncle and aunt had spent the day scolding him for not knowing a good thing when he saw one. No matter how Professor Guderian pleaded or persuaded, he had insisted he needed to think.

"What's there to think about? Still hoping for Harvard, are you?" His aunt had finally snorted in contempt.

Chen Motong had been right. It was because of Chen Wenwen.

He had read a StarCraft story called "The Bloodstained Totem," about a giant robot fighting on another planet that secretly used the military network to chat on QQ with a little girl on Earth. Under low, lead-gray clouds, the robot, named Godzilla, fought Zerg through hails of bullets while exchanging warm little messages with the girl.

One day, Godzilla told her on QQ, I'm going to die. All my battery fluid's leaked out. I'm running out of power.

The girl said, You're funny. You really think you're a giant robot? If you don't feel like talking, just say so. See you tomorrow.

Godzilla said, Talking with you feels so nice.

Then it was forced offline. On a distant planet, an angry Zergling leaped onto the wreck of a giant robot and tore through its circuits with sharp claws.

Lu Mingfei felt he was that giant robot, and Chen Wenwen was the little girl. Sometimes she told him very private things, and he was happy, replying with all sorts of cute emojis to show he was listening carefully. But she never understood why he did it, and didn't know that he waited for her on QQ, hour after hour. If one day the circuits inside the giant robot called Lu Mingfei failed, would Chen Wenwen feel sad?

The more he thought about it, the sadder he became. It was a tragic feeling: battery fluid leaking through his chest, circuits crackling all over his body.

The literary club's group chat was silent. Without Chen Wenwen, no one would ever discuss literature. The beauty of literature was mainly a matter of the beauty of the muse. The muse sat in the sunlight in a white cotton dress, her long hair loose. That was the beauty of literature.

In the StarCraft channel, Old Tang was imparting secret techniques to a crowd. Ever since defeating Lu Mingfei, he had styled himself the channel's top player.

The big-faced cat avatar flashed. Nono was online.

Lu Mingfei hesitated. "It was you?"

"Yeah. Chen Motong." Her reply felt lazy. "Nothing to do, so I came on for a couple of games."

"How did you know my ID?"

"Crowdsourced stalking. Heh. You actually use an ID like 'Mingming.' Sounds like a girl. And 'Sunset's Imprint'… Are you pretending to be a girl online?"

"You could even dig that up? Keep it secret, please. That's just me messing with my cousin."

"Kidding. Norma found it. A piece of cake for her. You're pretty good at StarCraft."

"Come on. I lost to you."

"I lost. Norma was playing with me. We both controlled the same side. At the end, I knew you were teching to tier three because she secretly revealed the map and saw it."

"May every cheater's whole family drop dead!" Lu Mingfei typed.

It was automatic. Everyone tossed that line around in the group. Nobody took it seriously.

"I'm the only one in my family," Nono replied.

Lu Mingfei paused. "Sorry."

"What's there to be sorry about?" Her reply was flat. "Want a game?"

"Not in the mood."

"Girl broke your heart?"

A shiver ran through him. Nono was like a little witch, seeing through everything about him, leaving him nowhere to hide.

"Not yet… I don't have a girlfriend, so obviously my heart isn't broken. What do you want from me, big sis?" he typed.

"'Big sis.' That's sweet." Nono sent a toothy grin. "Come on, tell me what's going on. Maybe I can help."

"How could you help? You don't even know her."

"No, I don't know Chen Wenwen." The little witch replied instantly.

"How much do you actually know?" Lu Mingfei was suddenly terrified.

"Too much."

"Who… are you people?" His hands were shaking a little.

"Suspicious, right? Your parents haven't been home in six years, then suddenly recommend you to an American college. Your grades are average… no, actually, they're terrible, but the college gives

you a huge scholarship. You clearly talked complete nonsense in the interview, but the interviewers say your answers were wonderful. Compared with that, knowing who you have a crush on is nothing."

"Yeah. Only my uncle and aunt don't suspect anything. They think my parents can do anything. All the way home, they kept asking how to get my cousin sent abroad, too."

"Beg me! Beg, and I'll tell you things. Like… what Chen Wenwen's thinking…" The little witch's evil nature was stirring again.

"You know?"

"A woman's intuition tells me…"

"What?"

"She doesn't like you."

"Get lost!"

Lu Mingfei didn't believe it. He remembered that afternoon when only he and Chen Wenwen had been in the classroom. He was wiping the blackboard. She sat on the teaching platform in a white cotton dress, sneakers, and white ankle socks, humming softly. The slanting evening sun shone on the newly replaced desks. Virginia creeper hung down outside the window. In that evening between spring and summer, everything was especially still. Suddenly, Chen Wenwen had turned and asked, Lu Mingfei, would you like to join our literary club?

He had felt petrified, only his heart still hammering. Outside, flowers and grass grew wild, the sun sank, the cicadas seemed to sing a hundred times faster. Time slipped through his fingers, the hours changed, yet the gaze between him and Chen Wenwen seemed eternal.

"Just kidding. Come on, let me advise you. Have you ever given her flowers?" Nono asked.

"Does foxtail grass count?" He perked up and began talking nonsense again.

"Taken her to a movie?"

"When the school screened revolutionary films for educational purposes, I sat next to her at Sparkling Red Star."

"When's her birthday?"

"October tenth."

"Ever given her a birthday present?"

"She borrowed my pen to write back to the boys who sent her birthday cards. Then she didn't return it. The next day she said it could count as my present…"

"Could you be any more hopeless?"

"I don't think so."

"You're a disgrace to Cassell College!" Nono was angry. "Come on. Let your senior teach you a thing or two. First, you have to pursue a girl! If you don't make a move, do you expect her to confess to you? Second, what matters most to a girl is feeling happy and cherished. Have you ever tried making Chen Wenwen feel that way?"

"Happy and cherished?" He stared.

"For example, suppose—and this is only hypothetical—Chen Wenwen really likes you, but you don't feel anything for her. Then one day you fail an exam and feel utterly miserable. Suddenly, there

she is, picking you up in a Ferrari. In front of everyone, she strokes your hair and says, ‘There, there. Don’t worry. You’ll do better next time.’ Wouldn’t you practically explode with happiness? Even if you didn’t like her before, wouldn’t you fall into her arms on the spot?”

“Immediately! No hesitation! I’d put a leash around my own neck and run after her barking!” Lu Mingfei answered with absolute conviction.

“Hopeless! That makes you look way too easy. At least squirm a little and pretend to resist!”

“Senior… what should I do, then?” He was entirely sincere about becoming her pupil.

“Burn your boats! Tell everyone you like her. Say it loud. Gamble your dignity as a man and your future on it. Do you understand girls? No girl will really hate a boy for a confession honest and brave enough. Even if she doesn’t accept, she’ll remember you.”

“What if she doesn’t accept?”

“Fly to America with your beautiful memories of heartbreak.”

“That sounds pretty tragic…”

“Loving someone isn’t easy. You have to fight your way through an army! The last Zergling, racing through the fire of countless Dragoons, down to its final hit point, slashes out with one claw and turns the battle! If you die halfway, that’s natural enough. But a Zergling that won’t charge into the guns isn’t a good Zergling!” Nono said.

Lu Mingfei paused. He felt the killing intent in her words, and that beautiful, indifferent face suddenly appeared before him. That girl like a blade of steel… Now she had swung it, cutting straight into his heart, blood splashing everywhere. In that instant, he made the boldest decision of his eighteen years. He would be the Zergling that charged into the guns. In those final three months before graduation, the last time he and Chen Wenwen would be classmates, he would tell her he had liked her for three years. However feeble that final swipe, whether or not it broke through her defenses, he was determined to be a good Zergling!

“Understood!” he said.

“Bring flowers. If you don’t know what she likes, go with roses. Deep red. No girl really dislikes roses. Have moving music in the background. Most importantly, say it in front of everyone. That shows your courage!” Nono said. “Good luck, little bro!”

“Yes, ma’am!” He imagined a mighty female general issuing orders to him, her foot soldier.

“But… if you succeed, the road to Cassell College will close to you forever!”

With that, Nono logged off, giving him no chance to reply.

Lu Mingfei tipped back his head and let out a long breath. He was eager to try, convinced that this bold confession would succeed. Giving up America for it was nothing. He would never see Nono again, though. That was a slight regret. He felt he would miss her. Before Nono, no girl had ever burst into his world with such ferocity. Not even Chen Wenwen.

He looked at the gray big-faced cat avatar, no longer bouncing, and suddenly felt it was a kind of magic. The moment his confession succeeded, Cassell College, Professor Guderian, and Nono would vanish from this world like bubbles.

In a suite on the Regent Hotel’s executive floor, Nono sipped her coffee at ease.

QQ was still open on her Apple laptop. She had merely set herself to invisible. Lu Mingfei's final message arrived: a simple "Thank you."

In another chat window, someone with the ID "Sonic" said, "What are you doing? Teaching him how to confess to a girl? If our S-rank gives up the gate to Cassell for love, the principal will go insane."

"Are you nuts? I'm just messing with him." Nono wrinkled her delicate nose and smiled coldly. "How could that kind of confession work? Chen Wenwen's a literary girl. If she likes someone, she'll accept him. If she doesn't, she won't care how much he offers. Music, roses, and shouting 'I love you' are supposed to do it? Please!"

"Could you be any more immoral?"

"No." Nono shrugged. "I have to admit, this is the most immoral thing I've ever done."

"Why pick on a freshman?"

"A freshman? He's S-rank! You and I are only A-rank. If we don't bully him while we have the chance, it'll be harder once he gets to college," Nono said.

"Let's hope nothing unexpected happens. Suppose Chen Wenwen's just as secretly passionate as he is. She's liked him for three years but won't say it, and all they're missing is a confession. Then you'll have ruined everything."

Nono stuck out her tongue. "Surely I can't be that unlucky?"

"The Student Council needs someone like him. The only S-rank. We absolutely can't let the Lionheart Society get him!" Sonic said.

"Nono." Ye Sheng opened the door and poked his head in. "Professor Guderian wants you to join the discussion."

"Oh." She slipped on her cotton slippers and trotted out, holding her coffee cup.

In the outer room, Professor Guderian, Ye Sheng, and Aki Sakatoku sat around a coffee table, looking rather grave. A freshly printed document lay on the table.

"Nono, I have an assignment. I can only entrust it to you." Professor Guderian picked up the document. "The college just faxed us the profile of a Russian candidate who appears to have an excellent bloodline. I must fly to Beijing at once and connect to Russia. I'm leaving the rest of Lu Mingfei's enrollment to you."

"Me?" Nono stared. "What about Ye Sheng and Aki?"

"Operation Kuimen has been moved forward. The principal will soon be coming to China in person. Professor Mans has ordered us to report to Sichuan immediately," Ye Sheng said. "Aki and I still need some time for coordination training."

"Is it really that urgent?" Nono pouted. At moments like this, she still looked like a child.

"When it's your turn to carry out an operation, you'll understand. You can't wait an hour, or even a minute." Ye Sheng patted her shoulder. "Miss certain moments once, and you might as well have missed an entire lifetime."

"You should say that with your hand on Aki's shoulder. Then add, 'So I'm asking you to marry me,'" Nono said, unable to resist.

Aki blushed.

"All right. What do I do about Lu Mingfei?" Nono looked at Professor Guderian.

He scratched his head. "If you want to know what I really think… bring him to America even if you have to kidnap him!"

Lu Mingfei thought Nono was an angel who brought good luck. Not long after she logged off, Chen Wenwen suddenly spoke in the group. All the invisible members promptly appeared and clustered around their muse, each brimming with literary eloquence, nothing like people suffering through the nightmare of college entrance exams.

"Shall the literary club have a graduation party before we graduate?" Chen Wenwen suggested.

Everyone cheered, Lu Mingfei among them. Hardly anyone in the club would oppose her suggestions. Zhao Menghua joked that she was the club's Liu Bei, with an irresistible power to attract men.

"A dinner? Boring. I'm on a diet," Su Xiaoqiang said coldly.

No one had expected her to condescend to join the literary club. The presidents of both the tennis and pool clubs admired her and had eagerly invited her, but she hadn't given either a second look. Instead, she had joined the club run by her sworn rival, looking less like a recruit than someone who had come to wreck the place. Her target, though, was Zhao Menghua, not Chen Wenwen. The Little Celestial Princess made no secret of it and announced it far and wide. Once, treating the girls to Pizza Hut, she had suddenly stood up, raised a glass of beer, and declared, "I invited you all to dinner to tell you I like Zhao Menghua. If you want to fight me for him, come on. I don't care how many of you there are!"

Majestic!

"Not dinner. Let's rent a small cinema auditorium and watch a movie," Chen Wenwen said.

Lu Mingfei's heart stirred. Nono's words echoed in his ears. A small cinema auditorium? Heaven was being far too generous. It sounded like a venue prepared especially for his confession!

"What should we watch?" someone asked.

"WALL-E," Chen Wenwen said.

"WALL-E? Sure! Let's sneak snacks in," Zhao Menghua said, using its English title. An English fanatic like him never watched dubbed Chinese versions and referred to blockbusters only by their English names.

"I'll cover popcorn and Coke. Nothing else!" the Little Celestial Princess announced grandly.

"Then we're a perfect match. I'll cover eating the popcorn and drinking the Coke," Lu Mingfei couldn't help quipping.

"Please! Who's a perfect match with you?" The Little Celestial Princess expressed boundless contempt.

Everyone chimed in, excited. Renting a theater with the club before graduation and watching an animated love story sounded like a wonderful memory.

A love story! Love was the crucial part! Lu Mingfei felt flowers blooming in his heart.

As if it were some mysterious sign, Chen Wenwen had chosen WALL-E. The story of a grubby little trash-collecting robot who fell in love with EVE, a snow-white robot girl like a princess. Lu Mingfei had watched it over and over. He was too embarrassed to admit that the final sequence had

moved him to tears: WALL-E crushed into scrap by the evil captain robot, EVE racing to find parts to save him, breaking the sound barrier with him in her arms.

That must be love. Even a little garbage-collecting robot could have his springtime! Lu Mingfei found it overwhelmingly moving.

"Lu Mingfei, come buy the tickets with me. Everyone, give your money to him," Chen Wenwen said.

The group agreed. As an officer of the literary club, Lu Mingfei's main duties were collecting money from everyone and running errands. Giving him this job was standard practice.

But this time, Chen Wenwen had said she would go with him.

Walk the same road with some people, and it feels absurdly long. Walk it with others, and it is so short you can hardly bear to take another step.

Lu Mingfei and Chen Wenwen ambled along the cobbled riverside path, dawdling and swaying with every step. He walked it after school every day, but suddenly found it offensively short. Why hadn't the city government spent a little more and made this pedestrian street fifty kilometers long?

"Lu Mingfei, which university do you want to apply to?" she asked.

They had just reserved the auditorium. Afterward, he had gone with her to buy a paper bag of bellflowers. While there, he had checked the price of roses. With no holiday approaching, they didn't seem very expensive. He could scrape together enough for ninety-nine. Now she was walking home beside him, holding her bag of bellflowers. For the first time, he learned that she actually lived not far from his own home. She was wearing the white cotton dress from their first day of school. It smelled nice.

"Anywhere, as long as I can get in," he said. He was too embarrassed to mention that Cassell College had said he passed the interview.

"Will you apply locally?"

His heart gave a leap. She's quietly asking where I'm going! There's a chance!

"Anywhere's fine. A school with lots of classmates would be best."

She smiled without a sound and gave a soft "Mm."

They walked in silence with their heads lowered. He counted his steps, happy, feeling that some subtle understanding existed between them.

"Hey. Why do you look so bashful?" someone asked ominously from ahead.

Startled, he looked up. The girl before him lowered her enormous sunglasses, rolled her eyes at him, held her hands beside her ears like a giant deer's antlers, and called loudly, "Hi! Hi!"

Lu Mingfei knew exactly why Nono was putting on this warmth of old friends reunited. It was entirely for Chen Wenwen's benefit. He had experienced this little witch's methods before.

"A friend of yours?" Chen Wenwen was a little embarrassed, feeling overshadowed by Nono's princess-like air.

"Uh-huh." Lu Mingfei mumbled.

"Hi, hi! What a coincidence!" Nono bounced in front of Chen Wenwen. "You must be Chen Wenwen?"

"How do you know my name?" she asked, surprised.

"He told me. He said…" Nono stopped abruptly and looked at Lu Mingfei with wide eyes. "Oh, right. Don't you still owe me ice cream?"

Blackmail. Naked blackmail!

But as long as Nono didn't start spouting nonsense right now, he would do anything.

He quickly took out his money. "What flavor?"

"Vanilla with strawberry sauce." Nono removed her baseball cap and ran her hand through her long, dark-red hair.

He could only pay up. The three strolled along the river eating ice cream. Locust blossoms fell onto Chen Wenwen's white dress and Nono's baseball cap. Nono bounced along as though she had springs under her feet, while Chen Wenwen spoke to her softly. Lu Mingfei followed behind with his head down. Nono's arrival had stolen his chance to talk. There was nothing left for him to do.

"Does Lu Mingfei say a lot of bad things about me?" Chen Wenwen asked.

"No. He says he loves literature, so he joined the literary club."

"Oh. Were you classmates in middle school?"

"Elementary school. I've been studying in America since then. Only just came back." Nono turned to Lu Mingfei. "Remember all that Virginia creeper on our classroom building? I went back the other day. It's reached the roof!"

He nodded vigorously. The ice cream was worth it. Nono was an honest businesswoman, making it all sound wonderfully real.

"Did your family immigrate?" Chen Wenwen asked.

"No. I have a Chinese passport. I only went there to study. I'm a college sophomore."

"Did you skip grades? Lu Mingfei's only a high school senior."

"Oh, we weren't in the same class. I was his senior." Nono patched the lie instantly, apparently without blinking. "Isn't that right, Lu Mingfei?"

"Yes! My senior!" he said solemnly.

Nono's smile bloomed.

They parted at a fork in the road. Lu Mingfei and Chen Wenwen continued ahead; Nono took the other branch. Watching her bounce away, he felt that the girl was somehow unreal. She always gave him the sense that she might disappear at any moment.

Lu Mingze had been unhappy these past few days. Sunset's Imprint was hardly ever online, leaving him frantic. He monopolized the laptop even more fiercely, giving Lu Mingfei no chance at it. Lu Mingfei knew his cousin resented his extraordinary luck and wanted someone to confide in. He would have loved to hear those confidences… He simply hadn't had time to slip out to an internet café.

His aunt nagged Lu Mingze about spending too much time online and needing to study if he wanted to get anywhere, while, as usual, ordering Lu Mingfei to buy milk for tomorrow's breakfast. He stepped out and heard Lu Mingze suddenly grow agitated inside, for some reason, and start arguing loudly with her.

He didn't go downstairs. He climbed to the top floor instead. Above it was the roof, crowded with whining air-conditioning units. The stairs up had the atmosphere of a horror film. Cardboard boxes, two broken motors, a discarded sofa, and a wooden coffee table sat under layers of dust, with barely enough space to put a foot between them. At the top, building management had installed an iron gate marked ROOF CLOSED. Lu Mingfei hopped expertly over the junk like a nimble kangaroo. Just beyond the gate lay a few feet of shadow, and then an infinity of stars.

He squeezed through the gap in the gate, stood beneath the starlight, took a deep breath, and looked out over the city under the night sky.

This was his secret territory. Here, he was free to enjoy the wind, the light of the sky, and the changing scents of the city as spring gave way to autumn: sometimes locust blossoms, sometimes leaves, sometimes the sweet fragrance of pineapples sold on the street below.

He sat on the edge of the roof as though on a cliff, feeling both precarious and weightless, like a bird carried high on the wind.

The whole city was lit. Its hard skyline vanished into the glow. From a distance, the office towers looked like square cages woven from light. Farther away lay a broad lake. Beside it, traffic flowed along the elevated road, headlights merging into a river of light. Lu Mingfei imagined each point in that river was a living firefly, trapped within the narrow, curving road, able only to rush forward in search of an exit.

He wondered where his own exit was. He thought of Chen Wenwen.

After Nono had left that afternoon, Chen Wenwen had suddenly suggested going down to the river. Dandelions bloomed across the grassy bank, one fluffy ball after another. She picked many and put them in the paper bag with her bellflowers, then sat talking beside him, shoes off, feet soaking in the clear water. Once they went to college, she said, everyone would separate. Perhaps they would only meet in summer. Perhaps they wouldn't see each other for a long time. That was how many good friends slowly forgot one another.

As she spoke, sadness filled her eyes, even more than when she had been reading Duras's The Lover on the first day of school.

He sat beside her, looking into her eyes, watching the wind loosen the dandelion seeds in the bag she held and scatter them over the water like a little snowfall.

Deep inside his heart, a small bird seemed to flutter.

Now the phone against his chest vibrated.

"Lu Mingfei?" It was Nono's voice.

"Yeah," he said.

"I'll tell you a secret. Professor Guderian flies to Beijing tomorrow. If you want to enroll, you'd better decide tonight. We don't have many places. Wait too long, and you might lose your chance."

He grew anxious. "Can't you wait until tomorrow? Tomorrow…"

Tomorrow, he was going to do something earth-shattering, with success or failure hanging by a thread. If Chen Wenwen accepted his confession, he wanted to stay in China. Otherwise, all he could do was slink off to study in America, leaving a legend at his high school: a guy whose life had reached rock bottom, only for a stroke of dumb luck to land him an American college offer.

"No. Professor Guderian's already booked his ticket." Nono sounded cold.

After a long silence, he scratched his head. “Then… I understand.”

“What does ‘I understand’ mean?”

“It means… I guess I’ll have to pass,” he said.

“So you’re turning us down? That’s harsh! Chen Wenwen’s not even that pretty. Think carefully. The gate to Cassell College opens at most once for anyone.”

“Just because you’re prettier than Chen Wenwen doesn’t mean I’ll like you…” he said listlessly.

“A hero! I didn’t know you had that kind of nerve!” Nono seemed angry. “Fine! Goodbye!”

The call ended. Watching the screen slowly go dark, Lu Mingfei felt he had made an enormous gamble.

Now, gazing over the city in the night, he thought about tomorrow’s party. Chen Wenwen had asked him to give a speech. Before dozens of club members, he would do the most recklessly daring thing of his life.

“Only I have absolutely no way back; free to chase, with no one to refuse…” he hummed tunelessly.

Through the remarkable life that lay ahead of him, he would always be like this. Usually limp as a dried-up cucumber, but once he decided on something, as perky as a stalk of celery that had been soaking in water.

“I’m a guy who goes crazy once in a while.” That would later become a favorite saying of Ricardo M. Lu.

In the restroom at Wanda Cinema, Lu Mingfei faced the mirror, listening to his heart pound, going over and over whether he had thought of every step in advance.

The movie would begin soon. The decisive moment was coming.

Flowers, music, and a loud confession. Nono’s three secret weapons.

The flowers were ready. He had picked plenty of dandelions by the river that afternoon, tied them into a bunch, and wrapped them in a paper bag. At the last minute, he had abandoned roses. Chen Wenwen liked dandelions. They had more character.

The music was arranged, too. He had taken a genuine pack of Chunghwa cigarettes from his uncle’s drawer and exchanged it for two fake packs at the downstairs tobacco and liquor shop. One fake pack went back in the drawer. The other became a gift for the projectionist. It had always been one of his ways of raising funds. The projectionist promised to run a short clip before the feature: EVE carrying WALL-E through the sound barrier, with its overwhelmingly moving soundtrack.

He had searched online for his confession, assembled the most touching phrases, and prepared a speech in his head:

“It’s been three years, and now we in the literary club are probably going our separate ways. Once we part, perhaps we won’t get many chances to meet again. Every spring, summer, autumn, and winter, when flowers bloom and fade, when snow falls and melts, it won’t be this same group of us together. It makes me a little sad… As an officer of the literary club, I’m very happy to stand here and give our final speech. It should be addressed to all of you, but there’s only one person I want to speak to…”

At that point, the Little Celestial Princess, the least patient of them all, might jump up and shout, “Lu Mingfei, what are you babbling about?”

If she asked, he would answer in the fiercest voice he could muster, “Shut up! I’m not talking to you! I’m talking to Chen Wenwen! I’ve liked her for three years! I’m not waiting three years, then three more, then another three! I don’t want to be the ‘nice guy’ for the rest of my life!”

That last line, adapted from Infernal Affairs, made him feel like a real man. Tough was good. Better than sounding so wistful and indirect that Chen Wenwen handed him a “you’re a nice guy” rejection on the spot. That would be humiliating. No being a timid little bunny of a man. The most that would get you was a lifetime as every woman’s platonic friend!

He nodded hard at his reflection, face fierce, gaze sharp, conveying, Mingfei, you’re amazing!

“Lu Mingfei, what are you doing?” Zhao Menghua entered the restroom.

“My face suddenly cramped up for some reason. I’m moving it around to see what’s wrong.” Thinking quickly, Lu Mingfei turned, twisting his mouth and squinting even more extravagantly. “Do I look like Stephen Chow?”

“No. More like Arale.” Zhao Menghua handed him a bag. “Clothes. Change before your speech. Chen Wenwen says you should look a little more formal.”

Inside was a Korean-cut black two-button suit, a white shirt, and a narrow black tie, exactly the right size for his skinny frame. He had once wanted a suit like that, but his aunt had refused. How did Chen Wenwen know he wanted one? An enormous sense of happiness hit him on the head like a hammer, nearly making him dizzy.

He hurriedly reached for his phone to call Nono. He wanted to tell her that before the bayonets had even drawn blood, he was already sounding the victory march.

“Sorry, the number you have dialed is currently out of service. Please try again later…”

He slowly closed the phone. He supposed Nono had left, too, disappearing forever like fireworks and bubbles.

Now there truly was no turning back. He would confess, and he had to succeed.

He entered the auditorium. Su Xiaoqiang’s voice pierced his ears like a needle. “Ha ha ha ha! Look, everyone! A monkey in a suit…”

The dozens of club members, already seated with Coke and popcorn, burst out laughing. His face turned eggplant-purple.

“What’s so funny? We’ve got piglets in suits, too,” someone said.

The club’s fattest pair of twins, Xu Yanyan and Xu Miaomiao, came in wearing black suits as well. Equally round and plump, they stood side by side like two basketballs.

“You two giving speeches, too?” Lu Mingfei studied them curiously. All three were dressed identically.

“No speech. We’re just the background,” Xu Yanyan said. “Extras. There’s money in it. Why not?”

Confused, he glanced at Chen Wenwen. She gave him a slight nod, her eyes bright and clear.

“Stand there for your speech.” Zhao Menghua pointed to a sheet of copy paper on the floor in front of the screen. “Right on that spot. Don’t block the screen. We’ll be showing photos of the club.”

Photos of the club? He hadn’t expected that. What about the clip he had arranged?

The projectionist’s dependable figure seemed to appear before him. When Lu Mingfei handed over the cigarettes, the man had snapped his fingers with a look of supreme confidence, tilted his head

forty-five degrees, and raised a firm thumb. “The projection booth’s my turf! Don’t worry! It’s in the bag! I’ll cut it in somehow.” Lu Mingfei decided to trust him.

The lights dimmed. Only that sheet of white paper on the stage remained especially clear. All right. That was his stage. One battle in a lifetime. Win this girl, and happiness for the rest of his life was secured! Everything was ready: dandelions, WALL-E, the speech. Now he was suited, shod, and full of spirit.

He bounded onto the stage, stood on the paper in front of the screen, and took a deep breath, ready to shout to the whole world: Chen Wenwen, I like you!

Nono had told him to gamble everything a man had. He felt ready.

Suddenly, a brilliant light blinded him. The projector had started. Hushing sounds rose throughout the room. He raised an arm over his face. Damn it!

He hadn’t said anything yet. Why had the next part started already? Had the projectionist got the timing wrong? As his eyes adjusted, he suddenly saw Xu Yanyan and Xu Miaomiao standing to his left like two bowling pins.

“What are you doing up here?” he whispered at Xu Yanyan.

“Extras.” Xu Yanyan looked innocent.

He looked around. To his left, a huge, unmoving letter L appeared. The projector was putting letters on the screen.

People were still hushing him. Unable to stand it, he ran a few meters away from the screen to look.

One line: “Chen Wenwen, Lve Yu!”

He didn’t understand the two strange words, but sensed something was wrong.

“Get back! Get back!” Xu Yanyan whispered. “Without your letter, it doesn’t make a sentence.”

“Letter?” He looked again. Out of the corner of his eye, he saw Zhao Menghua leap onto the stage, holding a great bunch of deep-red roses, surrounded by his close friends.

This time, he understood. Cold spread inch by inch from his fingertips, into his heart, deep into his skull, into the joints still aching from all the running he had done to pick dandelions. Xu Yanyan and Xu Miaomiao were the two o’s. He was the lowercase i. Together, they made the perfect sentence: “Chen Wenwen, i Love You.”

A stylish lowercase i, no less. Lu Mingfei could have racked his brains forever and never thought of anything so romantic. But someone else had better brains, and much better English. He’d had an English tutor at home since childhood, after all. A stylish little i was child’s play for him.

Lu Mingfei looked at Chen Wenwen. She was looking at Zhao Menghua, her eyes holding something like the dew of a summer evening, about to spill. By the river, she had been so melancholy and quiet. Not now. He could see the joy in her eyes. He felt he had turned to stone and was about to crumble, bit by bit. Suddenly, he thought of the dandelions in his bag. After all his running on the way here, had they shed their seeds until only bare stems remained?

“Go back! Go back! The sentence doesn’t work without you!” someone shouted from below.

Slowly, he returned to the screen and stood on the sheet of paper, lowering his head to look at no one. The lowercase i looked especially wilted.

"Today was supposed to be our literary club party, but I wanted to take the opportunity," Zhao Menghua said loudly. "We're about to go our separate ways. I don't want regrets. I want to tell Chen Wenwen… Well, it's all on the screen… I had to take a chance! Otherwise, once we're scattered all over the country and never see each other, I'll have liked someone for three years without anyone knowing. How pathetic would that be?"

"Yes! Way to go, boss!" Xu Yanyan and Xu Miaomiao clapped, and Zhao Menghua's friends clapped with them.

"Leading lady! Onstage! Leading lady! Onstage!" Zhao Menghua had clearly prepared everything, even the cheering section.

A spotlight fell on Chen Wenwen. She stood, her white clothes almost translucent, like an angel. She inched toward the stage, blushing red enough to squeeze tomato sauce from her cheeks. Zhao Menghua's friends surrounded her, asking in the familiar tones of supporting boys in a teen movie, "Will you say yes? If you will, hurry up! Zhao Menghua's a great guy!"

Lu Mingfei watched Chen Wenwen, watched her lips. He could hear nothing else. For him, the moment was silent as death, and only one person's voice could break it.

Chen Wenwen's.

"I like… you, too," she told Zhao Menghua softly.

The silence shattered, like thunder tearing across the sky, lightning striking the heart of heaven, rain falling with a soft hiss.

Amid the noise came a sudden wail. Lu Mingfei looked up and saw the Little Celestial Princess run out with her hands over her face. They had been enemies for three years. Now, suddenly, he felt they had quite a lot in common. He almost wanted to run after her, pat her shoulder, and comfort her. But he was the i that wasn't allowed to move.

Everyone rushed up to surround Chen Wenwen and Zhao Menghua, like guests at a wedding. Lu Mingfei thought they must all have known. Only he and Su Xiaoqiang had been kept in the dark. Probably everyone had long since realized he liked Chen Wenwen. That was why no one had told him.

"Heh. So stupid," he told himself, bitterness rising all the way into his nose.

Music swelled. On the screen, EVE broke the sound barrier and crossed the sky with WALL-E. A girl using every power she had to save the little loser she loved, before the two nestled together to music from an old romance. Moving. Perfect for the scene before him. Zhao Menghua had an arm around Chen Wenwen, who rested her bowed head against his shoulder.

The projectionist came in through a side door, one of Lu Mingfei's fake Chunghwa cigarettes in his mouth. With his look of supreme confidence, he snapped his fingers, tilted his head forty-five degrees, and gave Lu Mingfei a thumbs-up, as if to say, Didn't your buddy deliver?

Have you lost your fucking mind, mister? Lu Mingfei wanted to grab his collar and shake him.

But he had no strength left. He slowly sank into a squat against the screen. No one cared about the words I Love You anymore. Even when he turned into a lowercase e, nobody gave him another look.

"Quite a surprise, huh, sister-in-law?" one of Zhao Menghua's friends asked heartily.

"Not at all. I guessed what you were up to ages ago. I just didn't say anything. You're all so shameless." Happy and shy, Chen Wenwen swung Zhao Menghua's hand in hers.

So everyone really had known. Even Chen Wenwen herself. Head hanging, Lu Mingfei quietly made for the exit. Behind him, EVE pressed her face to WALL-E's on the screen. The music was warm and sweet. Chen Wenwen was still EVE, but he wasn't WALL-E. He was nothing.

No, wait. He was the expendable supporting boy who had played an important role on the leads' road to love.

"Don't run off, letter! Don't run off! Extras get red envelopes, too!" Zhao Menghua's friend called after him. "Everyone gets credit!"

Lu Mingfei turned. Zhao Menghua closed one eye and made a face at him. He knew what that meant. He felt he should go back and fight him, but his PE grades were far worse than Zhao Menghua's, too. Besides, the other boy had a whole pack of friends. He had been a loser for so many years that he was used to it. He said, "Oh," then turned and went back toward the stage, back to being his i.

Light shone from behind him, like lightning breaking through dark clouds. Someone had pushed open the auditorium doors with force.

A few times in every life, you feel as though you have seen the gates of heaven swing open. Lu Mingfei had waited eighteen years. At the lowest, most pathetic moment of his life, the gates opened.

The angel who walked in swept her gaze around the room, her eyes sharp as knives.

Everyone fell silent. This stranger who had burst in outshone everyone present. Dazzling. So dazzling that Lu Mingfei thought she must have come purely to steal the show.

"Ricardo, we're running out of time. Are you staying for the rest of this?" Nono walked up to him, speaking in a clear, icy voice that everyone could hear.

Her entire style had changed. Her loose dark-red hair was now immaculately arranged. She wore a deep-purple skirt suit, a pale, moon-white silk blouse, purple stockings, and a full set of custom gold jewelry inset with amethysts. Suddenly ten centimeters taller than usual, she was so imposing that even Lu Mingfei's legs weakened. She caught him just in time and steadied him.

"Oh, I…" He was dazed. He had never felt anything like it. He had become the focus of every eye, like a kettle on a solar cooker, about to be burned by their stares.

"I told you not to wear discount clothes like these." Nono beckoned.

Two impeccably made-up girls pounced and began stripping off his clothes, fierce in their approach but gentle in their hands. He had no time to dodge. Nono took a comb from her small handbag and moved behind him to fix his hair, with a tenderness somewhere between his mother's and an older sister's. The girls were probably clothing-store assistants. They kept fitting and matching five or six suits and five or six pairs of leather shoes on him.

"Now that's our Ricardo M. Lu." Nono patted his cheek, smiling with lethal solicitude.

She faced his classmates, so only he knew what she was doing. Cheerfully, she pinched his cheeks into a fox's face, then a pig's. He knew she was delighted with how utterly pathetic he looked. This little witch would never let anyone get the better of her. She had to be the one who overwhelmed people, the one who rescued them, never the other way around.

"Zhao Menghua set you up on purpose, junior," she whispered.

"How do you know?"

"I used a little feminine charm, and your chubby friend told me." She looked extremely pleased.

"Feminine charm?"

"I spoke to him first. That's all." She pinched his cheek harder. "You think I'm as good to everybody as I am to you?"

The two assistants finished by placing a folded pocket square in his breast pocket, then looked to Nono for approval.

She looked him up and down and frowned. "It'll do. Still a long way below Ricardo's usual standards."

"Good evening, everyone. Ricardo has another engagement tonight, so we'll be leaving first. Enjoy yourselves. Have fun." She inclined her head to his classmates, wearing the flawless smile of a great household's steward: cool and impossible to fault.

"Ricardo?" Zhao Menghua asked.

"Ricardo M. Lu. That's what we all call him," Nono said.

"Let's go! Chin up, chest out! Stop standing there like an idiot!" She jabbed him in the waist.

He nodded and obediently headed out. She linked her arm through his, carrying a faint scent of perfume. Unfortunately, she now looked a little taller than he did. It felt like an older sister picking up her brother after school. He thought Chen Wenwen must be watching his back now, nestled beside Zhao Menghua. He had stolen Zhao Menghua's thunder, but gained nothing himself.

Everything scattered, like fleeting light.

A car waited outside: a Ferrari 599 GTB Fiorano, red as flame. He had read in car magazines that one of these cost nearly five million yuan. He gave Nono an uncertain look.

"Get in. Act natural. They followed us out to watch. Look as though you're thinking, 'A Ferrari? Whatever. At home, it's nothing but Bugatti Veyrons and Maybachs.'" Her lips barely moved.

He sat in the passenger seat, hands placed obediently on his knees. Nono started the engine, and the Ferrari shot forward like a horse freed from its reins. He knew he was getting farther and farther from his past. But he didn't look back.

At night, the Ferrari raced along the elevated road, lights blazing on either side. Watching them stream past outside, he felt he was dreaming. Now he had become one of the little fireflies in that river of light, surging forward with the others, not knowing whether an exit lay ahead.

"I never thought anything like this would happen to me," he murmured.

"Like what? The girl you secretly love slapping you beautifully across the face in front of everyone, then kicking you into a corner?" Nono glanced at him.

"Being picked up in front of my classmates by a hot girl driving a Ferrari."

"Damn it. The hot girl driving the Ferrari is out of gas," Nono said.

Their speed dropped sharply. The Ferrari turned off the elevated road and into a deserted side street. The engine died. They stopped outside a twenty-four-hour pharmacy, whose doorway supplied the street's only patch of light.

"Shit. Forgot to fill up." Nono slapped the steering wheel. "Let's get out and wait. They can send another car." She opened her door and hopped out.

"We could walk a little and get a cab," he suggested.

"No. I don't want to walk. I'm wearing heels." She rejected the idea for the simplest possible reason.

He looked below her suit skirt. Sure enough: Mary Jane heels at least ten centimeters high. Thanks to them, she had instantly evolved from an athletic girl into a glamorous young woman with an older-sister air.

Pleased, she stood close beside him. "See? Almost as tall as you."

"Would it kill you not to get one up on people?" He sat on the curb, hugging his knees.

Without worrying about her exquisite suit, she sat beside him, took out her phone, and texted.

"Why are you all so nice to me?" he asked.

"It's not 'all of us.' It's me. The college just wants you enrolled. It doesn't care who you like," she said. "Call it returning a favor. You bought me ice cream, didn't you?"

He suddenly turned to her. "Hey. You didn't plan all this, did you? You're all messing with me together? Otherwise, why were you dressed like that? You're not the type to play glamorous older woman when you've got nothing to do."

Nono made a face. "You're such a dummy. Who'd bother messing with you? I left in jeans and sneakers. When I found out someone was making a fool of you, I drove off to buy an outfit, changed, and ran in. I was running the whole way."

He looked into her eyes and knew she wasn't lying. He was so moved he almost cried, but held it in.

"It's nothing. If you enroll, you'll be one of us at Cassell. As your senior, I have to look out for you," she said.

"Do I still have a chance?"

"You're an exception. You get one more choice. The last one. Think carefully. Once you choose, turning back won't be easy." She patted his shoulder and smiled mischievously. "But joining us is fine now, anyway. Chen Wenwen doesn't like you, just as I guessed."

"Could you stop picking at the wound?" He turned away. "She didn't mean it. She just doesn't notice I exist."

"All right, all right, Romeo. In your heart, Chen Wenwen can do no wrong. She could slap you a thousand times and you'd still adore her." Nono shrugged. "She didn't know you liked her? She knew, and still let you make that fool of yourself?"

"Tell me. Why do you actually want me? Don't lie. Is it just my parents? Can you explain it? Even if I'm jumping into a fire pit, I ought to know why."

Nono slapped his forehead. "A thirty-six-thousand-dollar annual scholarship! If you won't jump into a fire pit that good, plenty of people will fight for the chance! Aren't you precious."

He had no idea how to handle her. He had worked out the pattern: if he became even slightly forceful, she became ten times more so. Force wouldn't work. He needed cunning. He nudged her with his shoulder. "We're friends, right? Give a friend a tiny hint." He held his fingers close together to show how tiny, his voice coaxing. "Otherwise, I'm all nervous. That's no good."

"All I can tell you is that you're extremely important to us. Admitting you wasn't Professor Guderian's decision. It was the principal's. As for why he thinks so highly of you…" A little fox's charm appeared in her eyes and brows. "Come on. Call me big sis!"

"Big sis," he said very clearly.

"Good boy." She was delighted. "But I don't know why he insists on admitting you either."

He was utterly defeated. "All right. I accept. What else can I do? I haven't revised properly. I won't get into a good school through the entrance exam. And after making such a splash in front of everyone today, what will they think of me?" He lowered his head. "If I don't accept, what am I supposed to say when I go back?"

He felt sad. The Ferrari before him, the little princess Nono beside him, the thirty-six-thousand-dollar scholarship, and distant Cassell College all seemed insubstantial as illusions. He didn't know why they had suddenly appeared in his life, or when they might suddenly disappear. He was the hero of a male Cinderella story. A witch had given him a beautiful friend and a Ferrari, but at midnight the spell would break and he would return to what he had been. What, exactly, was Lu Mingfei? What was he worth? Even he couldn't say.

Nono looked at his downcast eyes, his face plainly saying, I'm pretty sad. Something in her softened. Suddenly, she reached out with both hands and scrubbed his hair into a complete mess. "You look just like that little white rabbit the bear used to wipe his butt!" she said loudly.

She made him so angry he almost hiccupped. "You got used to wipe a bear's butt! Your whole family got used to wipe a bear's butt!"

She wasn't offended. Opening her arms, she tilted her head at him. "Come on, little bunny. Have a hug!"

Startled, he looked down. His gaze touched her chest beneath the silk, its curves soft as the ridgeline of spring hills, and he suddenly felt feverish. To avoid overheating completely and collapsing into her arms, he clutched his own chest and shrank back. "Why are you trying to cop a feel?"

She stuck out her tongue. "You look so pathetic. I'm comforting you. You think you're a tempting piece of tofu? At best, you're dried tofu!"

"Dried tofu has its dignity, too!" He could only talk nonsense to hide his fluster.

"Well? Made up your mind? Hurry up and decide. Miss this chance, and it's gone." As she spoke, she took off her heels. "My feet hurt. They hurt."

"I…" he said. "I've decided. I accept."

She set the purple-and-gold heels beside her and hopped onto the street in her stockings, unconcerned about the dirt. "Much better! See how much I sacrificed for you? I hate wearing heels. Call Professor Guderian. You have to tell him yourself for the choice to take effect."

"Take effect?"

"You're different from ordinary people. Your life has a hidden option. Once you make that call, it activates," she said. "We always say there's another choice. It's just a matter of whether you want it."

"A hidden… option?" He opened his phone and dialed Professor Guderian.

"Mingfei, I'm in Beijing. Have you decided?" The professor sounded even more nervous than he was, as though Lu Mingfei were a peerless beauty considering whether to marry him.

He licked his lips. "I have. I agree to sign the documents."

Nono was playing hopscotch on the paving stones, not looking at him.

"You confirm?" Professor Guderian was delighted.

"I confirm." Lu Mingfei felt his words were like a bride's "I do." They would shape the rest of his life.

"Authentication successful. Option activated. Lu Mingfei. Date of birth: February 14, 1992. Sex: male. Identification number: A.D.0013. Rank: S. Added to the Cassell College register. Database access enabled. Account activated. Course selection form generated. I am Norma, secretary of Cassell College. It is a pleasure to serve you. Your airline ticket, passport, and visa will arrive within three weeks. Welcome, Lu Mingfei." A composed female voice sounded over the phone.

Professor Guderian's voice returned. "Mingfei, your voiceprint signature is complete. Norma will take care of everything else. Just wait for the mail. Are you with Nono? Stay where you are. I'll send transport immediately. There are still a few signatures you need to put on paper."

The call ended. Lu Mingfei was still a little dazed by everything that had just happened.

"Norma's the college's central computer. A computer with a human personality. Leave anything to her. She's absolutely first-rate!" Nono said. "Come play hopscotch!"

"Oh. Sure," he said.

One, two, one, two. As he hopped, Lu Mingfei had no idea what was happening around the world. Everything so far was only the beginning. Huge numbers of data packets poured from the supercomputer called Norma, bound for different corners of the globe. The name Lu Mingfei appeared on many screens and was committed firmly to memory. Data locks released. Thousands of secret gateways across the planet opened to Lu Mingfei.

Cassell College opened its arms to its new student.

A tremendous noise traveled through the dark night sky. He looked up and saw a huge black shape approaching at low altitude.

"No way," he murmured.

"The old man's that eager to collect you?" Nono looked up. "He even sent a helicopter."

Friday, May 15, 2009. A black helicopter swept over the small southern city like a great bird, passing above the boy Lu Mingfei.

The curtain was about to rise once more on the war hidden within history.